



Emotional Intelligence

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*For Stress Relief, Effective Communication, Empathy,
Overcoming Challenges, and Conflict Resolution*

Avery Wright

EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

***How to Use Non-Violent Communication to Skyrocket Your EQ
(For Stress Relief, Effective Communication, Empathy,
Overcoming Challenges, and Conflict Resolution)***

**By
Avery Wright**

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EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

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Introduction:

Nonviolent Communication and Emotional Intelligence Come to the Rescue of Toxic Relationships

Do you think you are stuck in a toxic workplace filled with people of poor work ethics, poor communication styles, and poor management styles? What about other toxic effects of the workplace such as being laid off or fired? Are you reeling under the stress of workplace toxicity?

If you did quit from that place, you can still feel the negative impacts. Yes, it is possible that initially after quitting a job that you believed was bad, you felt a sense of relief. You think you are free from the negative impacts of toxic colleagues and bosses. Yet, after some time, negative emotions such as anger, hurt, resentment, and fear of uncertainty about another job are sure to come back.

Why do people get so frustrated at jobs? The reasons could be many including bad bosses, poorly performing co-workers, ineffective managers, and more. When co-workers don't do their jobs well, you end up sharing their workload over and above your own work. Ideally, such situations are to be managed and avoided by managers in the office, right?

However, in a real-world scenario, you will find ineffective managers who don't do what they are supposed to do, and you end up having to take on the workload of poor and below-average performers. Moreover, the internal politics between co-workers and managers in any workplace also tend to play a big role in increasing the toxicity of the situation.

For example, a co-worker could be great friends with the manager who is biased towards this person and because of which he or she is let off lightly while you get loaded with that person's work too. If you tried to complain, you could get into trouble for complaining as well.

Then, there are outsourcing measures adopted by companies resulting in loss of jobs. How do these companies manage such situations? While some do agree on providing severance packages to their employees, most others use unpleasant methods. Typically, people who need to be benched are given poor performance appraisal reviews hoping they resign on their own. People do end up quitting, some in tears and some with deep feelings of resentment and anger against their employers.

Also, isn't it true that some managers choose to put down their team members for their lack of team spirit because they do not attend social get-togethers? Now, there is no mandated job description that attendance at office parties is a must. And yet, some managers use this unfair weapon on many a hapless victim.

Such toxic situations in the workplace do sound familiar, right? How does one get out of such environments? Generally, you have the following options:

- Try and change the situation.
- Try and put up with what is happening.
- Move away from that place.

You are free to choose any of the above options depending on the situation and your specific need. However, no matter which route you take, you have to start the process of changing from within yourself and your internal communication methods. And that is what emotional intelligence is all about. Emotional intelligence is the ability to identify, understand, use, and manage emotions and feelings in ways that create positive outcomes for you and those around you. Managing emotions effectively includes positive results in the following:

- Stress release
- Effective communication
- Empathy with others
- Overcome challenges

- Conflict resolution

Emotional intelligence can be developed by working on some key abilities that help us manage our emotions which in turn help us manage toxic situations. Some of these abilities connected to emotional intelligence include:

- To effectively and quickly reduce stress for yourself at any given moment whether at home or the workplace.
- To identify and recognize your emotions, and managing them in ways such that they don't overwhelm you.
- To connect emotionally with other people using nonviolent communication including the right of choice of words and nonverbal communication cues.
- To use humor in any given stressful and difficult situation to diffuse stress and conflict positively and effectively.

Understanding, managing, and implementing emotional intelligence can be done through the process of nonviolent communication as proposed by Marshall B. Rosenberg, the founder of Center for Nonviolent Communication who believed that if we can use communication combined with compassionate give and take, then it is possible to replace grief, toxicity, and violence in our world with happiness, joy, and peace.

When you are in the midst of a toxic environment, and if you could step back from the stressful situation, and observe the surroundings and yourself, you will notice that there is a brutal and harsh tone in your self-talk. You are filled with self-recriminations along with a lot of negative emotions towards other people who you believe are responsible for your situation.

In such difficult situations, the blame-game is the first thing on the minds of most people. Instead of finding solutions to handle the toxicity at that moment, we begin to indulge in the conversations like:

- I should have done this instead of that.

- He or she could have easily helped me instead of ignoring me.
- I would have done that if only I had known this would be the outcome.

If we get stuck in these kinds of limiting self-talk, we will never find the courage and will to move beyond toxicity. Using emotional intelligence via the compassionate path of nonviolent communication will help you move forward.

Toxicity is not just limited to the workplace. Even in personal relationships, we are stressed out by problems created due to misunderstandings leading to the breakdown in compassionate communication between partners, family members, and friends. Here too, we are so overcome and overwhelmed by agonizing negative emotions that we wittingly or unwittingly indulge in non-compassionate communication resulting in increasing the pain in the situation instead of solving the problem.

Therefore, whether at the workplace or in your personal life, finding the right ways to manage and use your emotions effectively to help us connect with our compassion to pursue nonviolent communication is the path to happiness, joy, contentment, and overall peace.

Chapter 1:

Understanding Emotions and Emotional Intelligence

‘Boys don’t cry!’ ‘Don’t be so emotional!’ ‘Don’t let your feelings control you!’ ‘Control your emotions, and then we can talk about this rationally!’ Our life is replete with emotions. There is not a second that goes by without emotions affecting us in some way or the other. Ranging from sheer boredom to raging anger, the spectrum of feelings that exist in the human system is mind-boggling, to say the least.

Feelings are the core of every activity we indulge in. They are the powerful motivators and guiding light of our lives. They add meaning, energy, and color. When you have a good time with your friends, read a book that brings tears to your eyes, watch a horror movie that sends shivers down your spine, kiss or hug someone, or smile at someone, you are, in effect, connecting with the emotional experience of the other person. For that little duration of time, you are part of that person’s perspective, and therefore, emotions help you create connections with other human beings.

Many of the emotional expressions are universal and does not have to be taught. Blind people can smile when they feel happy or heard something funny even though they have never seen another smiling face in their lives.

Emotions play a very crucial role in the way we think and behave. Our emotions drive actions and influence all our choices both the big and small ones. Our feelings can be long-lasting or have a short duration. Examples of short-term emotional situations are:

- A flash of anger directed at your team member for a glaring mistake done in the presentation.
- Being upset with your child for spilling your coffee while he ran around your legs in the excitement of seeing you return from

work in the evening.

- A flash of hope when you see your favorite team trying their best to get the home run.
- Long-term emotions are those that last for a long time such as the enduring loss of a loved one which can last for years and years. So, why do we have emotions? Are they important? If yes, in what ways are they important?

The Purpose of Emotions

Emotions are an integral part of human life. Emotions have multiple purposes, and some of them are listed below.

Emotions drive us to action – Students feel the tension and stress of upcoming exams which urge them to study and work hard so that they clear the tests with flying colors. The emotions of stress and anxiety motivate students to work hard so that they perform well in exams. In the absence of these seemingly negative emotions, a student may not get the drive needed to study and pass tests and excel in life.

Without emotions like fear and panic, the human race may not have survived or evolved into the present highly advanced species that we are today. Emotions such as fear and anxiety are reflected in our physical body. Our muscles contract and become tense. We achieve high levels of focus and alertness so that we are prepared to save ourselves from potential dangers that are actual triggers of these emotions.

Contrarily, when we feel happy and free, our muscles are relaxed, and our brains are numbed into inaction. Therefore, emotions make us feel uncomfortable or at ease resulting in taking some urgent action or lull us into an environment of ease and comfort. In fact, Charles Darwin opined that emotions are survival adaptation mechanisms of human beings and animals.

He said humans and animals fled when they felt fear and panic, confronted the source of irritation when they felt anger and sought out a mate to express happiness when they felt love which resulted in creating their progeny. Thus, emotions serve as an adaptive tool driving us to act urgently and quickly to enable us to survive, prosper, and grow our race.

Interestingly, we are naturally attuned to involve in actions that result in happy emotions while trying hard to prevent negative emotions. For example, most of us love to watch TV or catch a movie after a hard day at

the workplace to feel relaxed and chilled out. We will avoid actions that create boredom, stress, anxiety or sadness.

Emotions drive our decisions – Our emotions play a crucial role in our decision-making process. Right from what we choose to eat to who we want to vote for, our emotions play a part in our choices. In fact, some research studies have proved that people with brain damage resulting in not being able to experience emotions fully have reduced capacity to make good decisions. Even those decisions that are supposedly based on rationality and logic are dependent on emotions.

Emotions help us connect with people – Our interactions with people are primarily emotion-based. It is important to let people know our feelings and emotions which are expressed in multiple ways including body language cues, facial expressions, or many times, by stating exactly how you are feeling through words.

Letting other people know your feelings and emotions help them to take suitable action. For example, if you are discussing a party that you attended with your wife, then it might be a great idea to let her know how you felt about it. Did you like it or not? Based on your emotions, both of you could decide whether you want to attend it the next time you are invited.

In the same way, emotions help us understand other people. For example, if your wife enjoyed the party even if you didn't, or vice versa, then the decision about attending it the next time could change. Emotions facilitate interaction with other people and help us understand ourselves and others in any given situation.

Therefore, emotions play a highly critical role in our lives and serve a wide range of purposes. Emotions can be long-lasting, fleeting, simple, complex, and everything in between. In fact, emotions create energy in our system to help us understand the world better. A combination of emotional energy and intelligence is what makes human beings a highly evolved species.

Yet, emotions can create havoc in our lives, if not handled properly. For example, uncontrolled anger can result in hurt and pain for everyone involved in any situation. Emotions such as happiness and joy help us gain energy whereas emotions such as anxiety, worry, guilt, shame, anger, resentment, etc. drain energy.

Interestingly, there are more negative emotions than positive emotions, and this is because the apparently negative feelings were essential survival adaptive tools for our cavemen ancestors. Negative emotions such as panic and fear helped our ancestors remain alert to all kinds of danger and helped them survive.

However, in today's world, excessive negative emotions create debilitating effects in our lives. And that is why we need to build emotional intelligence (EQ) which is our ability to manage our emotions intelligently. It is a measure of our ability to identify, use, understand, and control emotions in positive ways to keep out stress, communicate effectively, display empathy, overcome challenges, and resolve conflicts.

Importance of Emotional Intelligence

Many experts in the science and psychology fields are of the opinion that emotional intelligence (EQ) is far more important than Intelligent Quotient (IQ) for success and happiness. Emotional intelligence has five components including (each of which is discussed in detail in separate chapters in the book):

- **Self- awareness** – which is our ability to identify, recognize, and understand our emotions and our reactions to them.
- **Self-management** – is our ability to manage, adapt, and control our emotions, responses, moods, etc.
- **Motivation** – is our ability to use emotions to motivate ourselves to take appropriate actions and work towards achieving our goals and desires.
- **Empathy** – is our ability to discern and understand the feelings of others and use this emotional understanding for effective communication.
- **Social skills** – help us build relationships, connect with other people in our personal and professional lives, resolve conflicts, lead, and work effectively as a team member.

Emotional intelligence is very crucial to build a balanced, happy, and successful life. Managing your emotional intelligence is the gateway to overall happiness. Here are some excellent benefits of building a high level of emotional intelligence:

To develop and maintain excellent physical health – Negative emotions such as stress, anxiety, anger, sadness, etc. can have an incredible impact on our physical health and overall wellness. If you look back at your own experiences, you will find multiple occasions to identify such situations.

Suppose something happened in your office where your boss or colleague said something nasty to you, or you had a fight with your spouse. In such situations, it is a natural reaction to feel physically drained and fatigued. In

fact, some people can even fall sick because of their inability to manage negative feelings and situations.

It is even more common to leave out your daily fitness regimen during such bad days. These reactions can lead to reduced physical health. Managing these emotions is crucial to maintaining good health. A high level of emotional intelligence helps us identify stress and anxiety triggers which can be used to avoid or manage our feelings to minimize their impact on our physical health.

To improve our mental well-being – Emotional intelligence affects the way we look at life and its myriad problems and perspectives. You can manage your stress, mood swings, and anxiety levels by developing your EQ. A high level of EQ is directly linked to a happy outlook on life and an overall positive attitude.

Conflict resolution – With a high level of EQ, our ability to manage our own emotions and identifying and understanding those of others helps us resolve conflicts amicably. In fact, recognizing the underlying feelings early on can help us avoid conflicts altogether. A person with a high EQ has improved negotiating capabilities because he or she can easily give what others want by clearly discerning their underlying needs.

Improved relationships – People with high EQ invariably have improved relationships in their lives, thanks to their improved self-awareness and social skills. Understanding the needs and desires of others in our lives help us build strong, sustaining relationships that can last a lifetime.

Improved success – A high level of EQ translates to strong internal motivation levels resulting in reduced procrastination, increased confidence, and enhanced ability to achieve our goals and desires. All these aspects lead to higher levels of success than if you did not have a healthy EQ.

Improved leadership skills – With improved emotional intelligence levels, you are better able to identify and understand the needs and desires of your colleagues and teammates at the workplace. This attitude automatically

makes you a better leader. Recognizing and fulfilling your team's needs will motivate them to work harder than before and improve the overall productivity and efficiency of your team.

As an emotionally intelligent person, you can strategize the emotional diversity of your team members facilitating improved team efficiency and effectiveness along with a lot more camaraderie and cohesiveness among the members.

Emotional intelligence is a learned skill. Yes, the best thing about emotional intelligence is that you don't have to be born with it. You can easily build and develop it to lead a more fulfilling and meaningful life than before. This book aims to teach you how to use your emotions positively and make amazing changes in your life.

This book is an exploration of emotional intelligence, its definition, and its uses based on nonviolent communication (NVC) as proposed and propagated by Marshall D. Rosenberg, the famous American psychologist, author, mediator, and teacher.

Chapter 2:

What is Nonviolent Communication?

Human beings cannot live in isolation. We are a social species, and we need interaction and communication with other human beings for our sustenance. For us, connections with other human beings are not just a convenience but an essentiality for survival. Communication is the most basic need of any social group including animals. Every animal species has its own way of communicating and talking with each other.

Therefore, communication is a two-way process by which thoughts, ideas, and emotions are exchanged meaningfully. Talking to people gives us happiness and joy. Talking to people also makes us feel sad, angry, and resentful. What is the difference between the two types of talking? What is it in the process of communication that affects how we feel?

Violent Vs. Nonviolent Communication

What kinds of communication make us happy and joyful and what kinds make us sad, angry, and hurt? Violent communication creates sadness and hurtful feelings whereas nonviolent communication creates joy and happiness for everyone involved in the discussion. Violent communication can include a range of elements including:

- Judging and criticizing people, deciding good/bad behavior, right/wrong people and situations
- Having prejudicial views based on race, gender, caste, creed, nationality, or anything else
- Discriminatory behavior
- Finger-pointing and blaming
- Talking without listening
- Reacting negatively when angry
- Name-calling
- Using rhetoric
- Being defensive

Any conversation or interaction with one or more of the elements mentioned in the above list is bound to result in violent communication.

So, what is nonviolent communication (NVC)? It is a form of empathetic communication that is based on the belief that every human being is capable of compassion. Nonviolent communication is deeply rooted in compassion. Marshall B. Rosenberg, the founder of the Center of Nonviolent Communication (CNVC), believed that being compassionate is the natural state of being for all humans. It is natural to find joy and happiness in giving and receiving from the heart.

If this is true, what is it that disconnects us from our natural state of compassion and makes us behave exploitatively and violently? Also, what is it that helps us remain in this natural state of compassion even in worst-case scenarios? One of the biggest factors that affect our compassionate nature is language and communication. Many times, even if we don't

appear to talk violently in the physical sense, our choice of words can make an interaction violent inasmuch it causes pain and hurt to others, and that is referred to as violent communication too.

Why do we indulge in this kind of communication style? Dr. Marshall Rosenberg opined that this is so because we are trained to perceive and speak judgmentally, labeling elements as right or wrong, and evaluating things in ways that disconnect us from our natural compassionate nature. Nonviolent communication is an approach that teaches us to give and receive from our hearts so that we are reconnected to our natural state of compassion.

NVC helps us to overcome automatic, habitual reactions and responses and choose to express ourselves objectively and non-judgmentally by being conscious of our behaviors, feelings, and choice of words. NVC helps us to express ourselves honestly and clearly even as we listen and pay attention to others' emotions and opinions empathetically and respectfully.

In any interaction based on nonviolent communication, not only we are aware of our deep needs and desires but also conscious of other people's needs and desires. By careful observations, we are able to specify external conditions and internal thoughts and emotions that are affecting our behaviors, and then make appropriate changes to our communication style that facilitates compassion and understanding for ourselves and fellow human beings.

Nonviolent communication is a combination of four elements or components including consciousness, language, communication skills, and means of influence. Let us look at each of these four elements of nonviolent communication in detail.

Consciousness – An individual who displays consciousness in his or her communication holds four human values high in their life; collaboration, compassion, authenticity, and courage.

Language – A nonviolent communicator is one who understands the importance and value of words and how they can increase or decrease distances and connections between people.

Communication skills – Nonviolent communicators have excellent communication skills. Such people:

- Know how to ask for what they want
- Know how to listen to others even in disagreements
- Know who to collaborate with and find solutions that work well for all stakeholders

Means of influence – Nonviolent communicators accept and acknowledge the importance of ‘sharing power’ instead of ‘using power over others.’

Nonviolent communication helps us to live with deep connections with people and sensible choices based on facts enabling you to live a meaningful and happy life.

Marshall B. Rosenberg said, “Human beings are powerhouses of joy and happiness, and each one of us is capable of enriching lives through our words and interactions with other people. We can support great support. We can nurture. We can contribute and participate in other people’s enjoyment. On the other hand, we also have the power to make people’s miserable through our words and actions. It is up to us to make the right choice of learning the various aspects of nonviolent communication to enrich our lives and those of others.”

How is NVC different from other self-help, communication, and conflict management tools? - The uniqueness of nonviolent communication can be found in the following elements:

Assumptions of NVC are unique – The start of NVC itself is beautiful and unique. This communication self-help tool assumes that every human being is capable of compassion and love. We are all nonviolent by nature, and violence is a learned behavior supported by or taught by external

circumstances including but not limited to the prevailing culture and norm. Another important assumption of NVC is that all human beings have the same primary needs, and all our actions, reactions, and responses are used to meet these basic human needs.

The NVC tool is simple to learn and use – The process involved in using the NVC tool is simple to learn and master and equally simple to implement in our daily lives. The crucial thing about NVC is that it is not merely a communication tool. NVC techniques teach us how to stay connected with our life energy. It improves our consciousness by making us focus on how our thinking and communication impacts our daily conversations.

NVC can be applied effectively for a wide variety of purposes and needs – The use of NVC techniques is not restricted to any one or two communication needs. You can effectively use NVC techniques on a wide range of needs ranging from the personal, professional, business, interpersonal, family, parenting, sibling, and more. It also helps to overcome social issues such as alcoholism, substance abuse, recovery from trauma, and prisoner rehabilitation.

NVC promises amazing results – NVC techniques can transform destructive attitudes such as anger, resentment, and more. It helps you break destructive habits and convert them into life-serving and peaceful behaviors. NVC has been used all over the world to reduce conflicts in families and business organizations, increase trust, and foster deep emotional connections to benefit all stakeholders.

Benefits of Learning Nonviolent Communication

Learning the skills of nonviolent communication helps you with the following:

Conflict resolution – Nonviolent communication methods teach you to resolve all kinds of conflicts amicably. You will be able to get to the root of the dispute quickly, and effectively help you find solutions. With nonviolent communication, you will learn to improve your listening skills significantly which allows you to get enhanced levels of cooperation from the different people you deal with.

Nonviolent communication skills help you convert criticism and blame into a compassionate understanding of the other person's point of view. With the help of all these conflict resolution skills, your ability to reduce misunderstandings and prevent pain from similar mistakes both for yourself and the people around will improve considerably.

Improved personal relationships – NVC is great for personal relationships. Being skilled in nonviolent communication helps you deepen your emotional connections with other people. Your improved listening skills will increase cooperative interactions with your family and friends. You will find ways to get what you want without the use of guilt or shame.

Improved family relationship – With NVC, you will reduce sibling rivalry, and family conflicts and you will be able to help people in your family to go beyond power struggles towards an attitude of cooperation and trust. NVC teaches you the power of using unconditional love to bring a family together. As a parent, you will be able to nurture your children without stepping on their sense of autonomy and freedom. NVC skills teach you to motivate by sharing power with loved ones rather than using power over them.

Improved education system and better students – NVC helps us to optimize the potential of each student and strengthen their passion, interest, dedication, and connection to learning and development. NVC skills help to

improve connection and trust in the classroom and empower them to feel safe and secure. NVC helps to improve efficiency and cooperation among students and enhance teamwork in the classroom while strengthening the power of parent-teacher relationships; a key ingredient in the overall development of a student.

Self-healing and personal growth – NVC empowers you to change guilt and shame into learning elements. It helps you heal old, festering pains and also facilitates the elimination of old, limiting habits and thoughts. NVC helps you to remain connected with your desires, preferences, and needs. It teaches you how to cultivate the habit of eating by choice and not by habit; a crucial item for physical health.

Organizational effectiveness – NVC improves the productivity and effectiveness of meetings. Also, employees will feel an increased sense of morale, confidence, and team spirit, helping them improve their productivity for organizational effectiveness and development. NVC helps you optimize the quality of work and also the social benefits of your company to the community and society.

Anger management – NVC helps you redirect your anger productively before it can drive damaging behavior. NVC enables you to identify and understand the needs of your anger, the triggers that drive angry behavior both for yourself and others. NVC helps you overcome the challenges of anger and facilitates solution-driven proactive behavior instead of regretful reactions. With nonviolent communication, you will find ways to express your anger without harming anyone.

Business relationships – NVC helps in building employee loyalty and morale by helping them achieve their optimum potential. With NVC, you will find ways to resolve workplace conflicts effectively and with little or no residual damage. It reduces absenteeism and stress in the workplace. It helps in improved customer relationships by understanding and preempting their needs and requirements.

Spirituality – NVC helps you connect to your inner being. You will find that with NVC you are able to align your actions with your spiritual values and moral principles helping you lead a wholesome and meaningful life. NVC helps you overcome conditioned harmful behavior developed from your cultural background and connect with the whole of humanity. NVC helps you understand that identifying and satisfying your own needs is the first step to building compassion for others.

You can also reap all these benefits and more by learning and implementing NVC techniques in your life.

Chapter 3:

The Four-Step Nonviolent Communication Process

To reiterate one part of what was already said in the introduction chapter, the primary premise on which Nonviolent communication (NVC) works is that all human beings have the same basic needs. One of the most important human need is the sense that they are being listened to, understood, respected, and valued.

NVC techniques are all designed to have meaningful conversations that connect to everyone's needs, and not to 'win' or 'lose'. The four-step communication process of NVC includes:

- Observations
- Feelings
- Needs
- Requests

Observations

A neutral way of observing what is happening inside and outside of you is the first and foremost step in the NVC four-step process. In a conversation, this is best done by recapping what has been said by others without attaching any emotion to it. When you recap or summarize a person's conversation, it is imperative not to be judgmental about the 'story'. Recapping what the other person is saying helps in the following ways:

- It slows down the conversation giving everyone time to rethink and reconsider their understanding and interpretations. The person whose idea you are recapping feels that he or she is being listened to and understood; one of the most important human needs.
- Recapping helps people to enhance their memory about the conversation helping them recall it better in the future.
- It helps to catch and correct errors. When we are talking fast and without a stop, it is natural for all of us to make mistakes in the form of misplaced words or phrases that mean something quite different from what we actually wanted to say. Recapping helps in catching and correcting these mistakes. Recapping acts like an editing process of what was spoken earlier.

Recapping works extremely well when you use the first person. Instead of starting with 'You said that....,' it would be better starting with, 'I hear that you are saying....' Here are some examples of recapping:

Suppose your husband walks in and says, "Oh God! These immigrants have come into our country and are taking our jobs away." Your response would be, "Did something happen in the office today that is making you feel insecure about your job? Would you want to talk about that incidence?"

Notice, by recapping what your husband said, not only did you let him know that you were listening to what he was saying but also catch the underlying fears about something that happened in the office that day. Your recapping of his statements has made him think about what he said which,

in turn, will slow down his speed of thoughts giving him the necessary time to really comprehend his emotions and feelings. He is forced to reflect on what he said, and clarify his stance. Moreover, he feels a sense of connection with you, and he is ready to discuss the issue without letting the fears affect his judgment.

Feelings

The next step in the NVC four-step process is to describe and focus on the emotions and feelings, and not the situation. If you want to be heard, then you must describe your feelings and emotions, and not just what is happening because everyone can easily see what it is. What they cannot see are your feelings and emotions which makes it important that you reveal them through words.

The crucial aspect of expressing your emotions is to ensure not to make it feel like you are blaming someone or something. For example, if you say, “I feel misunderstood...” could translate to someone not making an effort to understand you resulting in transferring or laying blame on others.

“I feel good about what happened,” or “I feel bad about what happened,” is talking about your feelings. Similarly, asking someone, ‘How do you feel about what happened?’ instead of simply asking, ‘What happened?’ will shift the focus from the situation to the person’s feelings and interpretation. This makes people feel like they are being heard, and their concerns are being addressed.

Needs and Requests

The third step in the NVC four-step process is to identify the need behind the feelings or emotions. This approach is based on one of the assumptions of NVC which is that we all experience emotions because of an underlying need. So, the next step after identifying the feeling is to discern and identify it.

Human beings feel a sense of dissatisfaction leading to anger and resentment when we have unmet needs. Interestingly, the founder of NVC, Marshall B. Rosenberg noticed that nearly all human needs can fit into a small list of categories including honesty, connection, peace, a sense of purpose, physical well-being, and autonomy.

Identifying needs is the turning point in conflict resolution. You can ask questions that will bring the underlying need of the other person's emotions to the surface. For example, you can say, 'Can you tell me exactly what your concerns are and from where do these concerns arise?'

Similarly, when you are talking about your unmet need, you must explicitly express the problem. For example, in that husband-wife conversation, if the husband had said something like this, 'I am worried about job security if people are allowed to migrate without restriction,' would have immediately reflected the unmet human need of peace and well-being.

In any conversation, if two people are talking without understanding the drive and motivation of the other person, then the resultant conversation will look like two overflowing glasses of water with no space to hold anything more. In order to understand any person's perspective, you must first empty your mind so that there is space for what the other individual is trying to put in.

The Importance of Unlearning Old Lessons

Here is a beautiful Zen Buddhist story that illustrates the need to empty our biases to understand and appreciate someone else's point of view. A highly learned professor went to a master to learn Zen. As the master was filling the professor's teacup, the professor was continuously talking about what he knew and had heard about the subject.

The master listened without saying a word and poured tea into the professor's cup until it reaches the brim. However, the master did not stop here. He continued to pour the liquid resulting in the cup overflowing. The professor watched this strange action for some time, and then abruptly stopped talking about Zen, and told the master, 'Stop pouring. The cup cannot hold anything more.'

The Zen master replied, 'You are like the teacup. Unless you empty your cup, how will I fill it with what I know of Zen?' So, first empty your mind, and only then are you ready to receive more.

Every situation can be seen through this four-step process which can then be used to improve your communication style effectively. Here is an example that explains the use of the 4-step nonviolent communication.

Sharon's mother, Denise, is feeling quite frustrated with her daughter's annoying habit of bundling her socks into balls and throwing them all over the house instead of putting them either in the washing machine or the laundry basket. She has tried all the traditional methods of communicating her anger and annoyance; by screaming, cajoling, bribing, etc. Nothing has worked. So, Denise now decided to use the 4-step process of nonviolent communication.

Observations – First, she observes everything around her and the external conditions. Denise keeps out words like 'annoying,' 'frustrated,' etc. Instead, she observes everything in a non-judgmental manner. She notices the mess that the balled-up socks create in the living room, kitchen, etc. and

these are common areas in the home used by other members of the family too.

Feelings – Next, she looks at how she is feeling and recognizes and identifies some of the top emotions she is experiencing. Denise is frustrated, angry, and feels helpless.

Needs – Denise then looks at her underlying need in this entire situation. She needs the common spaces to look clean at all times so that everyone in the house can get together without any feeling of discomfort brought about by the odor of smelly socks.

Requests – After following the three steps, she words her communication like this: Sharon, I can see three balls of socks under the dining table, and two balls of rolled up socks under the settee in the living room. It angers me to see these lying around in the common area of the home because this space needs more order than your bedroom as everyone in the family accesses and uses it. Can I request you to put your used socks either in the laundry basket or the washing machine from now onwards?

The last sentence is the request part of the NVC process that has to be delivered so that others can clearly and unequivocally understand our needs. These needs are the ones that enrich our lives, and nonviolent communication is the way that helps each of us achieve our needs using our natural feeling of compassion to give and receive from the depths of our heart.

Chapter 4:

Self-Awareness and Emotional Intelligence

Let us assume a situation that is happening in your professional life. You own a small website-building firm that is doing reasonably good business. You have five employees working for you, and your professional life is well on its path to becoming a big success.

It is a clear Monday morning; sunny skies and all your employees have turned out. Your accountant prints out last week's sales figures and you are happy with the numbers. The present week also promises to bring in some good business. Everything seems hunky-dory, and you are feeling happy and good. There are no major strong emotions in your system currently.

Suddenly your phone rings and one of your topmost clients; one who contributes to nearly 20% of your business is on the line. He is furious because his website has stopped working, and he has lost a lot of business because of this, and he blames you for it and threatens to take away his business unless you find a way to correct the mistakes right away. In that spur of a moment, you become acutely aware of the following:

- Your heart is beating fast.
- Your hands are all clammy with sweat.
- You are unable even to form words of apology.
- You almost drop your phone.

You become aware that you are now anxious and the calm feeling you had a couple of minutes ago has gone! This is the most basic form of self-awareness which is a simple phrase to explain a complex network of information and data about your feelings, your thoughts, and all the things happening to you.

Self-awareness is a measure of how well you know yourself at different levels including the senses of your physical body, emotions, intentions, preferences, goal and desires, how you are perceived by other people, and more. The higher your level of self-awareness the easier it is to find ways to adapt yourself to different situations and requirements. And the better we can adapt our responses and reactions to the people in our lives, the more satisfying our relationships will be.

We are constantly bombarded by messages from all over the globe, and yet we know so little about our own selves. We don't know how to set up a conversation with ourselves and build our self-awareness. And when we don't know ourselves well, we fall short of understanding other people too. Our inability to recognize and identify our emotions reduces our ability to respond appropriately and in ways that meet everyone's needs.

Therefore, increasing your self-awareness is a crucial element to improving emotional intelligence. All emotions and feelings are nothing but bytes of data made up of energy. All types of emotions are giving us information of some sort. Even the unpleasant emotions give us valuable information. Therefore, emotions are always positive when it comes to how much we can learn from them. The more we tune in to our emotions, the healthier we become by leveraging the power of the data provided by the feelings.

Being Aware Of Your Emotions vs. Expressing Them

Yes, expressing your emotions is quite a different matter from being aware of them. How we express our emotions, or even whether we express them at all, is our deliberate choice. However, making the right choice regarding emotional expressions first requires you to be aware of them, to know they exist, and the physical and mental feelings they bring with them. Once we become aware of our emotions, then an entire gamut of how we can express them opens up, and you can choose what suits you the best at that particular point in time.

Reacting to emotions without being aware of them are automatic, and are neither guided by intuition nor by reason. Suppose you start your day with some negative experience. The unpleasantness of that bitter experience will invariably spill on to the day, and you will show your unhappiness and negative behavior right through the day without even knowing that these negativities are the residual effects of the morning unpleasantness.

Then, someone who cares for you and knows you well walks into your cabin and reminds you of your irritable state of mind right from the morning. That is the first time you are made aware of your feelings and emotions and their root cause. We are, in effect, startled into a state of awareness. Once we ‘experience’ our emotions, then our brains are wired into this experience, and it uses this new data to find ways to overcome your negativity. This new information gained by our brain through our awareness of the feelings is used to look at things in a positive perspective which was not visible before we became ‘aware’ of that nasty emotion.

The lack of self-awareness also can be damaging because you could have reached the brink, and if you still are not aware, then wittingly or not someone is going to push you over the brink. This situation happens because a limbic memory (something beyond our control) has been triggered, and we end up using responses learned earlier during our childhood days such as shrinking from our boss when he or she shouts at us just like how we behaved during our childhood days when some strict elder in the house or teacher in school screamed at us for some wrongdoing.

The lack of self-awareness results in the loss of self-control. Therefore, self-awareness is the first step to get back control of your life and empower yourself to react and respond appropriately. This self-control and the freedom to behave as you wish are the pillars that hold up the power of empathy and genuine concern for fellow-beings.

Most of the time, we are unaware of our emotions until such time they become very strong. It is important to know that just like how we are always thinking something (our thoughts never stop), we are always feeling something. Just like how we have to become acutely aware of our thoughts to be more intelligent, we have to become acutely aware of our emotions to become emotionally intelligent. We should learn to feel and experience our emotions.

Self-Awareness and Nonviolent Communication

Let us look at the four components of nonviolent communication through the lens of self-awareness and understand the connection between the two. The four pillars of nonviolent communication include observation, feelings, needs, and requests.

Observations and Self-Awareness

What is observation? It is our ability to discern the various stimuli that are driving our reactions and responses. The sight of a cute baby gurgling with laughter brings a smile to our faces. The sight of an image depicting a starving child in a remote famine-ridden place fills our heart with sadness, and many times, such powerful images can involuntarily bring tears in our eyes.

Observation is what we see, hear, feel, and sense the different stimuli within us and in our surroundings. The purpose of self-awareness is to be accurately aware and describe what we are reacting or responding to. The trick in self-awareness is to be aware of everything that is taking place at any point in time neutrally and objectively. You must be like a video camera that is merely capturing everything that is happening at the point in time without judging.

What we observe neutrally and specifically gives us the context for our reactions, responses, and the expressions of emotions and needs. The key element in building good observational skills is to be able to separate your own opinions and judgments from the description of the stimuli, and this attitude and approach are what will help in creating and maintaining nonviolent communication with everyone around us.

For instance, if we said, ‘You were rude to me,’ to someone, that person is quite likely to disagree with us. However, if we said, ‘When you walked into the room, I noticed that you did not greet me,’ they are more likely to agree with you because your description of the observation was accurate, objective, and did not include your own interpretation.

When we describe our observation in this way without mixing up our feelings in the description, the person you are speaking to is quite likely to involve himself or herself in this first stage of the conversation without reacting negatively, and more willing to move towards the feelings and needs aspect of the communication process.

Therefore, by becoming more self-aware, you learn to translate your own opinions, interpretations, and judgments into an objective observational language. This approach helps to move away from our feelings of right/wrong. Consequently, we will find it easy to take responsibility for our actions because this objective outlook will direct our attention to the fact that our feelings are a result of our needs, and does not have anything to do with the other person(s).

Therefore, building observation skills helps us develop increased self-awareness, helping us get closer to our true self. Increased self-awareness builds our relationships and connections with other people as well, and our overall consciousness will shift towards becoming more authentic than before.

Feelings and Self-Awareness

What are feelings? They represent our collective physical sensations and emotional experiences connected to our met and/or unmet needs. Self-awareness is our ability to identify and label these feelings, again without judgment. It is important to focus on words that express the feeling and emotion instead of focusing on words that express our interpretations and opinions on the actions of other people.

Here is an example to illustrate the above point; telling your partner ‘I feel lonely,’ describes your feeling. However, if you said, ‘I feel that you don’t like me anymore,’ is a description of your interpretation of your partner’s behavior. Expressing your feelings is continuing to take responsibility for your actions and your experiences.

Here is another example to illustrate how increased self-awareness about your feelings and emotions can help you manage difficult situations. Suppose your new team member goofed up big time on a very important project that is due in a week.

It is true that you are angry with him or her for the mistake committed. However, if you include your own feeling of anxiety about completing the project well and on time, then your reaction to the person’s faults will be more wholesome, and you will be in a better frame of mind to help the new person to correct the errors and still meet the deadline.

Consequently, the listener gets to hear about your feelings without the burden of having to take blame, criticism or responsibility for your experiences. This kind of a situation enhances the chances of the outcome of the communication process to meet the needs of everyone concerned.

Identifying and labeling emotions is a critical step to building self-awareness, improving your nonviolent communication capabilities, and increasing your emotional intelligence. Remember there are no good or bad emotions; there are only emotions. Yes, some of the feelings may appear to be more pleasant to experience than others. However, every emotion is

giving you valuable information, and self-awareness helps you discern this valuable information.

Also, feelings need not always accurately reflect the situation. It is possible for you to feel guilty even when you know you have done no wrong or feel a sense of panic when there is really nothing to fear or a sense of joy even in a toxic relationship. Even misplaced emotions are communicating something important to you.

For example, if you are feeling unduly guilty, then maybe it is time for you to start creating boundaries for yourself and reducing other people's expectations from you. Feelings of misplaced fear could be an indication that this is new territory for you, and you will benefit from the learning.

All this can happen only when you become increasingly aware of your feelings, and delve deep into your psyche to try and analyze them, and see whether or not they fit into the situation that created them in the first place. Here are some feelings and what they might convey to you. Remember this list is only a guideline to get you started on increasing your self-awareness about your feelings. You could build your own set of guidelines as you become increasingly aware of how your emotions play out. Also, remember the intensity of the emotions is telling you something.

Love – Love could be telling you that something (or everything) about a particular relationship or situation is going well.

Grief – Sadness or grief is an indication that you need love and succor from others. It is important to listen to this emotion and reach out for help because unresolved grief can lead to disastrous outcomes.

Guilt – Guilt is typically an indicator of some mistake we have done. You can use guilt to correct mistakes. Undue guilt could be an indication that you have let others raise their expectations from you excessively.

Shame – Perhaps, one of the most unpleasant emotions to go through, shame also has a purpose. The biggest disadvantage of feeling shame is that

it makes us feel inadequate and flawed, and these negative feelings could drive us to go into hiding which is counterproductive to solving problems.

For example, if you are ashamed of being overweight, then not being socially active could be a way of hiding this feeling. Identifying and labeling this emotion is the first step to correcting such faulty beliefs, and finding ways to overcome challenges that are creating the feeling of shame in you.

Anger – This is a powerful emotion that tells us that we have been wronged. The most basic reaction would be to either confront the person who is the cause of your anger or simply speak to someone you trust and express your anger openly. Accumulating anger is one of the most debilitating ways of handling this potent feeling. You can channelize anger into productive work.

Anxiety – There are two types of anxiety namely productive and non-productive. The productive anxiety is giving you mature advice to remain on your guard and alert to get the best outcome for yourself to achieve all your dreams and desires. Non-productive anxiety, on the other hand, is debilitating to the point of not allowing you to do your regular daily tasks. It increases stress and reduces your ability to get things done effectively and efficiently.

Happiness – Like love, the feeling of true happiness is an indication that something is going right. Happiness can be felt even during difficult phases of your life. For example, if you have not had enough money to take your children out for a fancy Christmas dinner but have managed to cook up some amazing food for them at home, and they have that grateful smile on their faces despite their disappointment, you will feel happiness.

Needs and Self-Awareness

All human beings share critical survival needs including food, sleep, shelter, rest, and a desire to connect with other human beings. Other than these basic needs, we have other needs that we share. These needs are experienced by different people at varying degrees of intensity. Some of us need the feeling of connection more than others while some might have an increased need for self-esteem.

Moreover, in different situations, our needs could be different. For example, when at home, one individual might need the attention of his or her spouse more than anything else while at the workplace, the same person might not need the attention of other people.

Self-awareness is to be totally aware of these deep longings that form the foundation of our life purposes. When we are deeply aware of these longings, then we are able to connect to ourselves in a much better way than before which in turn helps us build better relationships with other people. Being aware of our needs helps us behave and act in ways that meet everyone's needs.

Most often, we express our wants and needs through a strategy of asking for something from someone. For example, 'Please come to my birthday party,' is a specific strategy that reflects your need for love and companionship on that special day. Once you shift your focus from the strategy to the underlying need then you liberate yourself from finding having to limit the ways of meeting that need. You are ready to explore other alternatives. Moreover, when you become aware of the fact that everything you do or say reflects an underlying need, then you will also learn to understand that the same holds good for others as well.

When needs are met or unmet, feelings arise. Feelings are triggered by our experience associated with the unmet or met needs; positive if met and negative if unmet. When we connect our feelings to our needs, we take responsibility for our emotions resulting in blame-free and criticism-free relationships with others.

Requests and Self-Awareness

Requests represent strategies that help us meet our needs. Identifying and accepting this deep connection between requests and needs will enhance our self-awareness. Quite often, in any given moment in time, the responses of other people to our requests are based on our connection with them. For example, if you ask someone, ‘What do you think of this?’ their response to your question is dependent on your connection with them then.

The most important element of creating strategies through requests is to be ready to take ‘no’ for an answer and continue to seek out alternative solutions either on your own or with the help of others. A critical difference between a demand and a request lies in our response to a situation when the other person denies our request/demand. In the case of demand, a denial typically leads to conflict or some other sort of punitive consequence whereas a denied request usually leads to further dialogue.

In a request scenario, a ‘no’ is nothing but an expression of some unmet need for the other person which is preventing him or her from saying ‘yes’. Increased self-awareness will alert you to the fact that saying ‘yes’ to your request is proving very costly for the other person, and a bit of negotiation is in order to make sure that both your needs are met.

Here is a classic example of how to discern between an undoable demand and a doable request that meets the needs of everyone concerned. Suppose you have an employee who has a problem with coming late. One way of ensuring discipline is by saying, ‘I want you to be on time to the office consistently.’

However, this is undoable because obviously there is some need of his that is being unmet which is why he is not able to come on time. Moreover, he is bound to come up with some excuse each day even after promising to be on time due to other unmet needs that were not resolved with your undoable demand.

Instead, if you told him, ‘Can you spare me 15 minutes so that we can discuss how we can help each other to make sure you don’t come late to the office every day?’ Now, this request is doable because not only is your need for time discipline met but also the employee’s needs of confidence, connection, trust, respect, responsibility, etc.. This willingness to work together to meet everyone’s needs is a sign of high emotional intelligence and a key differentiator of a highly self-aware individual.

Tips to Build Self-Awareness

So, how can you build your level of self-awareness to develop your emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication skills? Here are some tips for that:

See yourself objectively – When you see yourself objectively, it is easier to come to terms with your weaknesses and feel proud of your strengths without bordering on arrogance. For example, think of your current situation, and write down your thoughts. Here are some prompts:

- What are you good at?
- What do you need to improve on?
- What are the accomplishments are you proud of?
- What are the things could you have done better?
- What are the happy memories of your childhood? What has changed since then, and why?

Seek out people whom you trust and ask for honest feedback – Knowing yourself also means knowing how other people perceive you. This can be quite a challenge because most people find it difficult to give honest feedback. The ones who dislike you will be critical of your every effort, and those who like you might not want to hurt you by giving criticisms.

It is only those who truly love and care for you who will give you honest, upfront feedback; using which you can progress in your self-awareness journey. Keep track of such people, and always keep them in your life.

Maintain a journal – Write down your thoughts in a journal as often as you can. Doing it every day before you go to bed is the most effective way of looking back on your day objectively as you note down the events and your accompanying thoughts and feelings.

However, sometimes, during highly emotional periods, you might want to write down your intense emotions immediately. Don't hesitate to make a note in little chits of paper. This action of transferring your thoughts into a

written form is a great way to release the emotion-driven stress from your system. Make sure you write down both the good and bad things that took place during the day.

Also, write down your needs, plans, goals, and priorities. Thoughts are nebulous and putting them down into words and saving them on paper is the best way to read and learn from your experiences later on.

Allocate some time for self-reflection – Increasing self-awareness means you have to be with yourself for some time. Use this alone time for self-reflection. Don't skim the surfaces of your emotions. Dig deep and ask yourself why you are so happy. Don't feel ashamed to face your jealousies and other weaknesses. There is nothing wrong about having flaws. What is wrong is not finding the courage to fight them and overcome them.

Focus on your breath – Get away from the hustle and bustle of your daily life for at least 15 minutes each day. Choose any convenient time. Find a quiet, undisturbed, and comfortable spot. Sit down, and close your eyes. Now, observe how you breathe.

Don't try and control it. Simply observe the inhalation and exhalation process. Your thoughts are bound to wander away. Bring your mind gently to focus on your breath. Initially, 15 minutes will seem like a long time. However, soon you will find that you feel more connected to yourself than before. You are comfortable being alone with your thoughts. You like solitude.

Practice mindfulness – Mindfulness is the science of 'living in the moment' so that you experience and engage with life fully. Immerse yourself in every action you are performing. Focusing on your breath is a deliberate mindfulness exercise. Here are some more.

For example, when you eat your meals, the current trend is to watch TV or carry on a conversation with other people. For your next meal, focus only on eating your meal. Take small bites. Chew at least 20 times before swallowing. Focus and feel the flavor, texture, and taste of the food. Don't

focus on whether you like it or not. Simply focus on the sensations in your mouth and tongue.

When you are walking, focus on the sensations on your legs, how the calf muscles, ankles, and other parts of your legs are moving. Focus on your breathing. Is it very fast or is it slow? Don't try to control it. Simply observe all your feelings and sensations.

Slowly, with practice, you will find yourself becoming increasingly productive and efficient because your entire being is focused on this one act. You will find yourself being able to recognize every feeling your body senses as you eat, sleep, walk, wash dishes, breathe, etc.

These are some of the most basic methods of developing self-awareness. The more self-aware you are, the better control you have over how you choose to react and respond to your emotions.

Chapter 5:

Emotional Intelligence and Self-Regulation

Avery returned home after a hectic day at the office and found her 2 four- and five-year-olds squabbling and fighting with each other over some small issue. Avery is dog-tired, and moreover, she had a tiff with her boss leading to negative emotions swarming her body, heart, and mind.

She walks into the apartment and sees her children screaming at each other while her husband is watching his favorite game on TV seemingly unperturbed by the noise in the house. Avery loses her temper and shouts at her children to shut up, and the scared children scoot away to their room while her husband glares at his wife for losing her temper in this extreme fashion in front of the children.

Avery sat quite stunned at her own action and felt miserable for her behavior. She went and apologized to her children, and yet, that seed of fear for their mother's temper was already sown in their minds. The problem in this situation was not that Avery had a bad day, and she was feeling overwhelmingly tired and emotionally drained. She could feel these emotions strongly. She was intensely aware of her grief and pain. However, what she lacked was the ability to manage and regulate these emotions appropriately and maturely.

Therefore, in addition to being self-aware, you must skill yourself to manage and regulate your emotions to achieve high levels of emotional intelligence. Being aware of your anger, and then choosing to express it on some hapless victim is not a sign of emotional intelligence.

Self-regulation of emotions does not translate to subduing, making or hiding your true feelings. It means to recognize them and manage them appropriately. Self-regulation means showing maturity when you express your emotions. It translates to expressing your emotions appropriately and

in a dignified manner. People with high levels of self-regulation skills are also very sensitive to others' feelings, and will always use nonviolent communication methods.

Self-regulation is thinking before acting. The thinking time gives you the needed timeout to bounce back after failures and disappointments and also lets you plan your reaction maturely after resounding successes before impulsiveness tears you down.

In short, self-regulation involves controlling your behavior, emotions, and limiting thoughts for delayed gratification, and to achieve long-term goals through the art of nonviolent communication. Self-regulation consists of five different components including:

1. Self-control
2. Trustworthiness
3. Conscientiousness
4. Adaptability
5. Innovation

Let us connect with each of these elements to understand them better.

Self-Control

Self-control is the ability to keep a firm leash on our emotions, desires, and appetites. People with self-control can manage and temper their needs and wants to match their capabilities and strengths. People who have good self-control have the following habits deeply inculcated in them:

Self-preservation – Self-controlled people maintain a healthy approach towards their needs, and are aware of when they are crossing the limit to wander into ‘wants.’ They do not hesitate to get what they need to enrich their lives and those of their loved ones. However, they do not overindulge which could potentially result in exploitative behavior; a key element that is totally contrary to nonviolent communication.

Self-assertion – People with self-control do not fear to voice their opinions and concerns without trampling on or violating the rights of other people. They exhibit a firm and strong attitude without demeaning themselves or other people. They display a high level of assertiveness.

Self-fulfillment – This element is closely related to resilience. People with strong self-control know, understand, and appreciate the importance of persistent efforts even in the face of temporary setbacks. They know that perseverance might seem hard but has success and pleasure on the other side of it.

Therefore, self-control is the ability to enjoy and indulge in the good things of life without wanting something excessively and identifying the point when you have had enough, and need to stop indulging.

In this age of instant gratification, self-control is an undervalued virtue. Yet, it is worthy of developing as you will find it very useful to manage difficult and unpleasant situations with dignity and respect. So, when should you stop indulging? Or, when do you know that you need to exercise self-control? Well, you will need to exercise self-control in any of the following two conditions:

- When you feel an overwhelming desire to indulge in something pleasurable, but you know that the indulgence is not good for you.
- When you feel a sense of disgust at having to do something that is not so pleasurable, but you know that it is good for you.

Shame is an excellent emotion to develop your self-control. Generally, when you have not been able to exercise self-control and end up eating or drinking despite promising yourself not to, you feel a deep sense of shame because of having let yourself down. This feeling of shame can be productively channeled to build your self-control.

Observe the feeling of shame, and make notes in your journal without holding back anything. The next time you think you are losing your self-control, go back and read that piece about feeling shame, and it is likely that you can find the resolve to prevent giving in to your indulgent behavior. You will be able to exercise self-restraint in a better way than before.

Trustworthiness

Trustworthiness is the ability to maintain your integrity and to lead your life based on your core principles without compromising them at any point in time. Trustworthy people are driven by ethics, and will not do things that are morally and/or legally wrong.

Such people develop trust based on their consistent actions which are, in turn, a reflection of their core personal values. These people do not hesitate to stand up to confront unethical activities and take a principled stand even in the face of rising unpopularity for themselves. Here are some of the top traits of trustworthy individuals:

They keep their promises – Keeping promises is the most important and obvious element of trustworthiness. Trustworthy individuals will leave no stone unturned to ensure they keep all their promises. If for some reasons beyond their control, they cannot keep their promises, trustworthy people will quickly keep all stakeholders informed of an impending breach of trust well in advance. Other than these extremes, a trustworthy person will always keep his or her promise.

They handle pressure well – When under pressure, trustworthy people don't spew venom on hapless and less powerful victims. They will not humiliate others, raise their voices, or use their position to bully others. They will take some time off and get their emotions and panic under control before taking the stage.

They rescue people in trouble – Trustworthy people stand up for their people and team members. If for example, a team member was humiliated publicly (such as in an official meeting) for a mistaken presentation or something, then as a trustworthy leader, they will stand up for his or her team member, and find a way to help save face.

They do not indulge in cynicism and gossip – Gossip and cynicism are the tarnishing images of an untrustworthy person. Both these elements build

distrust and animosity. Therefore, trustworthy people will not indulge in spreading cynicism and gossip.

Trustworthy people have realistic expectations from others – Unrealistic deadlines from team members, unrealistic expectations from children, or unrealistic expectations from themselves are all things that trustworthy people avoid completely. Their needs are based on practical and doable actions, and consequently, they are able to create great loyal teams and keep all their promises.

Trustworthy people are ready to let go of control when the situation calls for it – For example, in an office environment, a trustworthy leader will be ready to delegate part of his work to his team members giving them opportunities to grow as well as a feeling that the leader is willing to put his or her trust in that team member. The second reason is one of the biggest confidence boosters for any junior team member and used by effective leaders as part of their nonviolent communication to build and develop trust within the team.

Trustworthy people always show gratitude – They are people who don't take anything for granted and are always grateful for the many good things in their lives.

Conscientiousness

Conscientiousness is being able to take responsibility for your performance ensuring your hard work maximizes your potential and capabilities. Conscientiousness is standing up for what you believe is right. Let us take this case study for illustrative purposes:

There was a team of college students who were collaborating to create a presentation for their final group assignment. It involved a lot of research work, collating data, culling the essentials, and then putting everything together in a nice-looking data-driven but engaging and interesting presentation.

Stefan, one of the students, said, ‘We will all split up the work, and complete the writing part of the project. Then, we can hand over the data to a friend of mine who will add the glitter needed to make it an amazing presentation. Anyway, none of us is skilled in that domain. And, we can get better grades too.’

Everyone, except Allen, in the group agreed. Anyway, there was so much to do, and final exams and tests and many, many more presentations have also to be prepared. However, Allen was not to be deterred.

He said, ‘I don’t think it is right to get our work done by someone else. After all, we are being graded against other equals in our class, and it is not fair that we get an undue advantage over them.’ The others were not happy and were irritated with Allen. But he stood his ground.

However, he added, ‘What if we spoke to the teachers and asked for permission to get that part of the work to be done by a professional, and it would hold for the entire class?’ The group agreed wholeheartedly.

This is classic conscientious behavior. It calls for standing up for the right thing even in the face of adversity and the risk of becoming unpopular. Conscientious people indulge in doing activities that do not give anyone an undue advantage in any way. Once they accept a task, then they hold

themselves accountable for it. Conscientious people know their limitations and will take on only that work that they know they can achieve well. They keep their needs within their capabilities.

Adaptability

A couple had been married for nearly 25 years, and suddenly, one day the lady wakes up and tells her husband that she cannot live with him anymore, and wants a divorce. The husband is devastated, and he begs and pleads with her promising to do everything in his power to keep her happy. But, she doesn't relent and walks out.

The husband doesn't know what to do. He rants and raves, and keeps hounding his wife. His behavior only drives her further away. The husband just couldn't accept this change in his life. What he forgot was that every day his wife was changing so that his life remains unchanged. Then, the time came when the wife reached her breach point and took the extreme measure of leaving her husband because she couldn't change anymore.

Emotionally intelligent people are adaptable in a healthy way. They accept changes positively not because they have no option but because they have the strength, power, and vision to create great opportunities for everyone concerned including themselves.

Adaptability is the skill that reflects your flexibility to adapt to changes. Human beings resist changes. You only need to see small children and their tearful faces when they endure the changing phases in their lives such as going to school. And yet, ironically, change is the only thing constant. If we don't build our capability to adapt to changes, it can affect our growth and development significantly. With the right mindset, we can convert our perspective on 'change' from problem to opportunity.

People with a high level of adaptability:

- Can manage multiple tasks, prioritize effectively, and adapt to changes rapidly.
- Can manage their responses and reactions for optimum effect in any given particular situation.
- Can see multiple perspectives which, in turn, gives them access to multiple solutions.

In today's fast-paced world, changes are not just inevitable but take place at rapid paces leaving those who cannot adapt quickly almost breathless. Therefore, adaptability is a key area of concern for people wanting to improve their emotional quotient. Adaptability is essential to move forward in the world even as you help others struggling to adapt to change to the best extent possible. Taking everyone together is the way of nonviolent communication.

Innovation

Emotional intelligence is about accepting change, and also bringing about change. Emotionally intelligent people are brimming with ideas. Innovation is not just limited to professional growth but is a useful skill even to build and sustain personal relationships.

For example, one of the biggest challenges of keeping old marriages going strong is to find ways to express love and romance in innovative ways. A long-lasting marriage can easily slide into ‘boring’ which is the beginning of the end unless both the partners innovate and bring joy and cheer to each other in new ways. Being aware of this aspect is a sign of emotional intelligence.

Innovation has three skills integrated with it namely persuasion, people management, and adaptability. Persuasion skills reflect your ability to convince and persuade others to invest resources in your ideas. People management skills reflect your ability to handle teams of varying sizes ranging from two (in a partnership like marriage) to many, many more (typically in the workplace situations where teams work together to meet a common end). Adaptability is, of course, the ability to adapt to changes quickly and effectively for positive outcomes.

Self-Regulation and Nonviolent Communication

Self-regulation is, therefore, a skill that allows you to manage and regulate your emotions, especially in emotionally charged up situations wherein your feelings could overwhelm you beyond your control. An individual with self-regulation skills can communicate compassionately with others which is the key element in nonviolent communication.

A self-regulated person can easily learn and understand the skills of nonviolent communication which helps people to:

- Talk in a way that inspires compassionate understanding.
- Start off difficult and unpleasant conversations easily and without much ado.
- Stay grounded and calm when listening to unpleasant and difficult messages.
- Discover the empowering strength of anger so that it can be used productively instead of using it to create valueless blame and criticisms.
- Bring about positive changes in the thinking process that could otherwise lead to excessive, and many times, undue feelings of guilt, shame, and ultimately, depression.
- Find happiness by discovering the power of gratitude.
- Convert negative feedback and criticisms into life-serving lessons.
- Heal painful relationships and help to resolve long-standing conflicts.
- Inspire people to make self-serving positive behavioral changes.

Picture this situation: A leader just watched his team bungle up an important presentation quite badly. When the presentation is over, this person might actually want to slam the door and walk out after giving a cold, hard stare to his team members. This would typically be a knee-jerk reaction of people with low levels of emotional intelligence.

However, a leader who knows how to self-regulate will step back from that highly charged position, and spend the time to plan his response carefully. He will first acknowledge that his team has goofed and will take responsibility for the event because he is the leader. He will brainstorm with his team for the reasons and causes for the fiasco ensuring there are no harsh judgments passed around.

Was the failure because of a lack of effort? Was his team at a distinctive disadvantage? What was his own role in the failure? Finding answers for such objective questions will be the primary purpose of the brainstorming session. A self-regulated leader will make sure that his entire team including himself have learned as much as possible from this situation, and if an opportunity knocks again, his team will be ready with a well-considered presentation incorporating all the lessons learned.

Therefore, learning to self-regulate will help in building nonviolent communication skills.

Chapter 6:

Emotional Intelligence and Empathy

Steve walked into his office on Monday morning, and found his secretary, Pamela, sitting with her shoulders slumped, and staring unseeing at something on her desk. She was obviously lost in thought, and clearly negative thoughts. Her frown was prominent, and her mouth was turned down in sadness.

She did not even hear Steve's good morning wish as she continued sitting unmoving on her chair. Steve left his office bag on his desk and came back to Pamela's desk. He touched her gently on her shoulders and shook her. She startled herself to the present time, and turned to Steve, and hurriedly put on a fake smile, and said, 'Good morning, Steve.'

Steve asked, 'Is everything alright?' She looked at him, and tears automatically welled up. She brushed them away, and said, 'I'm fine,' and went back to work. However, Steve did not let go. He said, 'Come to my office, and tell me what happened. Help me help you, Pamela.' She got up and followed her boss.

Steve not only showed concern for his staff but also very subtly displayed organizational intelligence. He knew and understood that in her current frame of mind Pamela would not be able to work to her best potential. Her needs have to be addressed first.

Therefore, instead of ignoring her obvious need for help, he chose to use his emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication skills to help build trust and empathy. This approach will not only help in addressing Pamela's problem but also the company's long-term productivity will be impacted positively as is bound to with happy employees whose needs are taken care of.

One of the most effective ways of showing your concern is by demonstrating empathy as illustrated by Steve in the above example. Empathy is, perhaps, the most crucial element for effective communication. Empathy adds a certain sensitivity to social interaction, fine tunes your social awareness skills, and helps you respond quickly and effectively to people's nonverbal cues. Empathy can be used to defuse tensions between two groups even before it leads to conflicts.

Moreover, the need for attachment, connection, the sense of belonging, and validation are all biologically wired into our psyche. An unfortunate element in the stress-filled modern-day is the lack of empathy. The modern-day culture that is so attuned to winning, success and coming first seems devoid of empathy as each person is trying to defeat the other person to take his or her place in the rat race.

So, what is empathy? The word was adopted into the English language only a century ago. Empathy has its roots in the German word, 'einfühlung' which translates to 'feeling into.' It is the ability to recognize, identify, understand, and be sensitive to another individual's thoughts and emotions without having the same experience yourself. Our need for empathy is based on our need to be fully heard, understood, and respected for our experience. In the same vein, giving empathy means to fully hear, understand, and respect the other person's experience.

The crucial thing to remember here is that giving empathy to someone does not mean agreeing with his or her ideas. It is only accepting and respecting what the person is experiencing and fully hearing his or her thoughts and ideas. Reflecting and paraphrasing what you heard is a great way to let the other person know that you are fully present in the conversation and you are following and understanding what he or she is relating to you.

When the speaker has completed whatever he or she has to say, and is satisfied that you have fully heard and understood his or her perspective, it is quite likely that they turn around and ask you for your opinion. At this point in time, it makes sense to present your viewpoints objectively and backed with solid reasons as to why you think differently. Therefore,

showing empathy does not compel you in any way to agree with the speaker. It only fulfills the speaker's need to be fully heard.

Empathy Vs. Sympathy

Empathy is defined as the ability to identify, recognize, and share the emotions of another person by seeing situations from his or her perspective. When you empathize, you share the other person's sadness or distress without going through the same experience as he or she is going through.

Sympathy, on the other hand, involves a sense of 'community feeling' or 'fellow feeling.' However, unlike empathy, sympathy does not include a sharing of emotions and feelings. For example, suppose someone tells you that he is feeling depressed because he has just lost his mother. Your response is, 'I lost my mother last year, and I know exactly what you are going through.' This would be sympathy and not empathy. Empathy is hearing and understanding the other person's perspective without going through the same experience or emotion.

Empathy and Emotional Intelligence

Empathy is the foundation of emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication. When you have to tell someone to empathize with another person, what do you say? ‘Put yourself in his or her shoes.’ Empathy allows you to communicate by understanding the other person’s ideas, thoughts, and emotions.

Why is empathy such an important element in emotional intelligence? With improved empathy, we can connect with our humanity. Empathy leads to more meaningful and stronger relationships than before. With empathy, you will find success in your workplace. Empathy helps you lead a healthier and happier life than before.

Nearly all forms of success, especially those that involve working with teams such as playing a team sport or building a business, are backed by the high emotional intelligence of the leader and the team members. Emotional intelligence typically starts with the leader, and the powers are then learned by the team members.

Empathy builds sustained relationships by building trust and openness and improving our understanding of the other person’s thoughts and ideas:

By building trust and openness – When you can empathize with people, you are effectively building trust and openness. When people see your concern, they are willing to be open with you and trust you with their secrets. With increasing trust, more information, thoughts, and feelings can be shared.

For example, if you notice a team member is worried about something, and you walk up to her and say, ‘I can see that something is bothering you. Would you want to talk about it?’ And, if the other person, ‘No, I rather not,’ then it is a sign that she doesn’t trust you.

An appropriate response from an emotionally intelligent person with a high level of empathy would be, ‘Sure, I understand your hesitation in discussing personal matters with me for the moment. I want to let you know that I’m

your friend, and would like to help you if you want. If you change your mind about wanting to talk, you know where to find me. Just remember you are not alone.'

Slowly but steadily, with your behavior and nonviolent communication skills, you build empathy and with it trust and openness. Soon, the team member will walk across to your desk and share her concern with you. And the next time, she will do it without your asking.

By improving understanding – Empathy calls for listening to the speaker with a focused mind. If you're an empathetic listener, you drop everything you are doing, and only listen to what the person is telling you. This form of focused listening helps you understand what is being said as well as what is being left unsaid through nonverbal cues, facial expressions, body language, etc. Empathy might not help you read people's minds, but it will definitely help you get into the person's head and understand what he or she is going through completely.

Empathy and Nonverbal Communication

Demonstration of empathy and emotional intelligence can be done through words and through nonverbal communication. Here are some ways to enhance empathy with people around you through the use of nonverbal communication:

Practice active and engaged listening – During any conversation, irrespective of whether it is with a friend, colleague, loved one, or anyone else, you can demonstrate empathy by practicing active and engaged listening. Avoid multitasking when someone is speaking to you.

Don't use your mobile phone or stare into your computer while someone is talking to you. Instead, pay attention to the person's words and the nonverbal cues, and let him or her know that you are listening attentively. Also, use paraphrasing and summarizing while you reflect on the conversation to ensure you have understood what the speaker intended.

Sit next to the person instead of in front of the person – Sitting in front might come across like a negotiation table involving a give-and-take approach. You need that attitude in some areas. However, when you want to demonstrate empathy, it is preferable that you sit next to the person.

Mirror the speaker's body language – When speaking to a group, ensure you are using an expansive and open body language. Use hand gestures to connect yourself to the group so that there is a feeling of unity in the situation. For one-on-one conversations, match the other person's body language, the tone of voice, energy levels and speed of talking. This attitude lets the other person know that you are with him or her the entire way.

Relax your facial muscles – Many times, in our earnestness to demonstrate empathy, we end up with facial expressions that appear rigid and strict. For some people, showing empathy may not come naturally even if the person is empathetic in the true sense of the word. However, for most people, empathy has to be demonstrated to be understood.

Therefore, you might have to practice soft facial expressions in front of the mirror. Practice the art of maintaining a soft expression on your face and eyes. Learn to smile tenderly. If, nothing else works, remember a genuine, honest smile of understanding is sometimes sufficient to let the person you care about.

Initially, practicing body language and facial expressions might seem like an act. However, it is important that your feeling of empathy is genuine. You are only learning to demonstrate that feeling in a language that is commonly accepted in society. Pretending to be empathetic without feeling any genuine empathy is not the way of nonviolent communication.

How Not to Express Empathy

While human beings understand the power of empathy, we also love to avoid pain. And being empathetic means feeling the other person's pain. Therefore, unwittingly, we end up falling into traps that appear we are empathetic but, in truth, makes the other person feel even worse than before. Here are some common pitfalls that we fall into when it comes to expressing empathy.

Comparing with a situation worse than the speaker's – Our primary intention is to compare the speaker's condition with another one that you believe is worse off. While this approach might seem that we are helping and empathizing with the speaker, in truth, we are, perhaps unintentionally, displaying a belief that their problem is not very substantial.

By comparing with another seemingly more difficult scenario, we are telling them their feelings and emotions are unworthy and invalid. This approach makes the speakers feel that they and their problems are not significant to you which is the exact opposite of what empathy stands for. Therefore, do not compare worse-than-this situations to express empathy.

Telling them to look on the bright side of the situation – When someone comes to us to talk about their problems, one of the most commonly used comforting sentences is to say, 'Don't worry. Every cloud has a silver lining,' or 'Look at the positive side of the situation; you can choose to look at a half-filled glass as half-full or half-empty.'

These 'positive-looking' approaches are really effective ways to helping people to find solutions for their problems. However, it is best not to use them to express empathy. By focusing on the positive aspect, we are, unwittingly belittling the speakers' emotions and feelings, and telling them, 'Ignore what you are feeling; instead, look at the good side.'

Again, this approach is contrary to what empathy means which actually requires you to behave in a way that makes the speakers feel that they are fully heard and understood. Empathizing with someone is to understand

what they are going through. They need empathy at that point in time. So, tell them what you have understood by paraphrasing and reflecting which makes them feel that you have gotten to the crux of their problems.

Once, they feel confident about your empathy and concern, then their minds are ready to find solutions to their problems. While expressing empathy, you simply need to be in their shoes.

Trying to problem-solve – Another common trap that we fall into is to jump into problem-solving mode when the speaker is only looking for empathy. Instead of being with the speaker, we quickly look for solutions thinking that we are helping the person.

We assume that the person who has sought us out to speak is looking for solutions. The typical layperson will think, ‘Why else will the person want to tell his or her problem to me?’ An emotionally intelligent person will quickly gauge that the speaker is looking for empathy, and will not problem-solve at this stage. He or she will listen most attentively to the speaker.

Elements of Empathy

If you are conscious of the following elements of empathy as you interact with the speaker, then your empathetic feelings will be easily gauged by the other person:

Your presence – Listen in rapt attention to what the speaker is saying. Focus on the words and the nonverbal cues of the speaker. Avoid thinking about what he or she is saying. In fact, you must empty your thoughts, and only concentrate on the speaker's voice, the tone of voice, rhythm, the in-between silence, body language, facial expressions, and everything else about the speaker's speech so that you completely comprehend his or her thoughts, ideas, and emotions.

Silent empathy – This element of empathy refers to listening to the speaker without undue interruptions, and ensuring you catch all layers of communication. Your focus on the speaker should be such that you can guess his or her explicitly narrated feelings, unsaid emotions, underlying needs, and their unspoken requests.

Conveying your understanding of the speaker's narrative – The most critical aspect of empathy is wanting to be fully heard and understood as per their meaning. For this, as the listener, you must reflect back what you have heard in your own paraphrased words so that you are completely convinced they are being empathized.

The most important element in this aspect of empathy is to indulge in the reflection and paraphrasing action in a way that does not imply your agreement or disagreement with the feeling, emotion, or thought. By reflecting and paraphrasing, you are only conveying the fact that you understand what they are feeling, and you have heard them fully.

Use of the 'need' language – The trick in showing empathy is identifying the underlying need in the situation being discussed. The reflection and paraphrase should typically include the underlying need that you are hearing in the conversation. In fact, once the need has been identified, the

speaker generally connects with you accepting the fact that you have clearly and fully heard and understood him or her.

Empathy also involves taking a step back sometimes – Suppose you had a loved one who has been diagnosed with a chronic illness, and he is in terrible pain day in and day out. Asking the person how he or she is feeling is not showing empathy at all. In fact, such people feel the pressure of having to say ‘fine,’ even when they are not which aggravates the pain.

In such situation, it is important to step out of his space, and not make it harder than it already is for him. Unless there is an update on the illness or the treatment process, it makes no empathy to repeat asking this person how he is feeling. Just let him know that you are there for him and that he only needs to ask, and you will come running to help him.

How to Increase Your Empathy Quotient

Finally, here is a small step-by-step process that you can use in any conversation to build and develop your levels of empathy.

Step 1: Listen well and speak very little – We are attuned to talking more than listening. The first lesson to becoming more empathetic than before is to listen more and speak less. Indulge in active listening and here are some tips to improve your listening skills:

- Give undivided attention to the speaker.
- Give sufficient time for the speaker to deliver everything he or she wants to say. Do not interrupt them except in extreme cases when you think you haven't heard something correctly. In fact, allow the speakers to rant. Emotionally flustered people need to give vent to their emotions, and this is where your empathy will come in useful. Let them talk their hearts out.
- Show your curiosity by asking insightful questions relevant to the topic that is being discussed.
- Paraphrase and summarize your understanding.

Step 2: Give voice to your perspective – Once the speaker feels satisfied that his emotions and thoughts have been heard and understood well, then it is time for you to give your viewpoint. Here are some examples:

- I totally get your feeling of anger in this situation. What he/she did is quite hurtful.
- I can understand why you are feeling so helpless.

Put yourself in that person's shoes, and feel his or her emotions, and let those emotions guide you when you give your perspective.

Step 3: Display your vulnerability – Many of us are under the misconception that displaying our vulnerability makes us appear weak or foolish. However, in truth, our vulnerability helps us create strong and sustainable bonds with other people. When we display our vulnerability, we

are telling the other person that we are human, and we feel the same pain that they feel.

One way of showing our vulnerability is to try and recall a similar situation that you experienced earlier. Don't compare the situations. Just use it to bring up the feelings that you had at that time, and use these emotions to respond empathetically to the speaker.

Step 4: Don't Make Any Assumptions – Assumptions are antagonistic to empathy. Making assumptions are creating shortcuts to understanding a situation. We don't want to ask questions or try to know what exactly is plaguing the speaker. Assumptions come in the way of making the speaker feeling fully heard and understood.

Empathy takes time, and assumptions don't. Don't rush to demonstrate empathy without truly understanding the situation the speaker is in. Take some extra time, ask relevant questions, clarify your doubts, and then demonstrate your understanding of the speaker's emotions and thoughts.

In summary, empathy is one of the primary elements of emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication. Empathetic people can spread this critical element of EQ to others as well, and slowly but surely, the world can become a more empathetic place that displays compassion and love.

Chapter 7:

Emotional Intelligence and Motivation

Another important element of emotional intelligence is motivation which can be defined as your personal drive to achieve and do better than before. Motivation also involves the level of commitment that you show towards your goals, your initiative, and preparedness to grab opportunities that help you achieve your goals. Motivation is a synonym for initiative, enthusiasm, and persistence.

The HR Manager of a company was given the daunting task of looking at the company's persisting employee turnover problem, and to come up with solutions to counter them. The lady in question, Marlene, had 2 months to do the needful. For inexplicable reasons, she kept putting the work on this particular project off. She seemed overwhelmed and was not able to gauge what should her starting point be in this big messy problem.

One day, Marlene had a call from one of her old school friends about a reunion at school. Although she seemed excited at the prospect of meeting old friends, Marlene declined the invitation and told her friend that she could not make it to the reunion. When she put the phone down, it suddenly registered that the reason she could not take on any additional activities was that she felt no motivation other than to do her day-to-day work. She was already drained out and fatigued, and simply could not muster the necessary motivation to do more than absolutely necessary.

The work that was given to Marlene merely remained another chore. What enhanced the value of the work is her own motivation to find solutions. So, in the absence of motivation, a critical emotion for initiative and drive, that task remained untouched in the file, and unless something happened, then it will be labeled as undone.

The thing about motivation is that it drives action not only for yourself, and its energy is so deep and strong that you can motivate others to bring out the best in them.

What is the meaning of motivation? Motivation is what drives you to do something. Typically, all motivations are based on 'pleasure' and 'pain.' We move towards what gives us pleasure and move away from what gives us pain. Here are some classic examples of 'pleasure' motivation that draws us to them:

- Survival needs including food, clothing, protection, shelter, etc.
- Accomplishments and achievements such as career, college, sports, business success, etc.
- Fun and enjoyment such as partying, playing, laughing, dancing, indulging in a hobby, the taste of food, etc.
- Curiosity or the urge to know and learn more.
- Sex and drugs that release dopamine, the 'happiness' hormone
- Money which is connected to the idea of freedom and abundance
- Social status.
- Individuality which is a sense of being unique or special.
- Adventure or the feeling of excitement.

Things that bring pain and drive us away include:

- Fear of loss.
- Fear of the unknown.
- Fear of being rejected.
- Fear of failure and disappointment.
- Fear of uncertainty.
- Fear of change.

Many times, we are motivated to do some things to ensure we are moving away from these pains.

The Source of Motivation

The purpose and meaning attached to every task is ideally the source for motivation. If you are working like Marlene in your office, have you asked yourself recently this important question, ‘What is the purpose of my work?’ The purpose and meaning of your job is not just achieving sales figures, cutting costs, keeping employee turnover within reasonable limits, etc. It is the ultimate reason why you are doing all these activities.

Motivation does not come from external factors. Yes, many times, we feel the pressure put on us by our bosses to achieve our workplace goals. However, these pressures and stresses deplete our creative energies and are very, very difficult to sustain in the long run. Motivation, on the other hand, is something that is internal and represents our true needs and wants. Motivation helps us focus on the external world to achieve our internal wants.

People with low levels or no motivation are those who are so caught up with the external pressures and stresses that they have lost touch with their internal fire. To reconnect with it, we simply need to rediscover our purpose. When we feel the drive to achieve something, our ability to connect with our emotions that help us achieve our goals increase which, in turn, builds our emotional intelligence.

In the context of emotional intelligence, motivation consists of four components including:

- Personal drive – reflects the depth of your desire to achieve and/or improve on certain standards in your life.
- Commitment – to both professional and personal goals.
- Initiative – reflects your readiness and preparedness to quickly identify and act on opportunities that help you achieve your goals.
- Optimism – is your ability to bounce back from setbacks and continue to pursue your goals, and not be deterred by failures.

There are typically two types of motivators; intrinsic and extrinsic. Intrinsic motivators drive us to do something because we want to or we find personal satisfaction. Primarily, intrinsic motivators are those that compel us to do what we love and enjoy.

Extrinsic motivators, on the other hand, are those that are done to attain some kind of reward which could be in the form of money, good grades, power, etc. Extrinsic motivators need not necessarily give us joy and happiness.

Let us look at some examples to understand the difference between extrinsic and intrinsic motivators. Julianna is a single mother working hard as a waitress to support herself and her school-going daughter. She hates her job which gives her no satisfaction or happiness. But, she is motivated by the money that she gets by working as a waitress. This is a classic example of extrinsic motivators.

Contrarily, John has a website designing business employing 4-5 people. He loves web designing and is motivated by challenging design jobs. He has money saved to lead a comfortable life, and so even if his business goes bust, he can lead a decently good life with little or no deprivations. He is in the business of web design because he loves it. John, therefore, is motivated by intrinsic motivators.

Of course, in the above two examples, Julianna is at one end of the motivation spectrum, and John is at the other end. Most of us in the real world fall somewhere in between the two extreme ends. Most of us work for the money it brings us but also, try to combine some intrinsic motivators to keep motivation levels high. Most of us try to balance our work-life scenario so that we get the money as well as get the time to do what we love to do.

Typically, human beings tend to work better if we love what we are doing. In fact, research studies prove that we are able to handle stress better if we do something that we like and enjoy doing.

Obligation and Emotional Intelligence

At this point in time, it might make sense to talk about something called obligation and its importance. We do some activities even if there are no extrinsic and/or intrinsic motivators. For example, you go to a party despite not wanting to or not having to. It could be because you feel obligated to the person who invited you, and you might not like yourself if you didn't go.

The importance of obligation in emotional intelligence cannot be underestimated. Commitment to obligations is a sign of maturity. Even if you don't like doing something, if you are committed to doing it, then it speaks very highly of your ability to manage your emotions, and get the work done well. To do something even in the absence of motivators calls for higher levels of maturity than being by extrinsic or intrinsic motivators.

Self-Motivation

Self-motivation has many elements to it including:

- Setting high but achievable goals
- Willing to take necessary risks to achieve goals
- Seeking feedback for improvement
- Commitment to personal and professional goals
- Actively seeking out and grabbing opportunities
- Ability to bounce back from temporary setbacks

Let us look at how some of the above elements help in building emotional intelligence:

Setting the right kind of goals – There is a powerful connection between self-motivation, achievement, personal goals, and emotional intelligence. When you set the right kind of goals, then you find the self-motivation to achieve them, and with your achievement comes confidence and the power to help others.

As you go through your success journey, you are bound to face setbacks and failures which will be great lessons in humility and the acceptance that things can go wrong anytime for anyone. Emotional intelligence is the ability to learn the right lessons from the mistakes and bounce back in the game. Therefore, setting the right goals (high goals but achievable by you) is a key ingredient for motivation, and finally, emotional intelligence.

Willing to take necessary risks – The willingness to take risks reflects the ease with which you are willing to step out of your comfort zone to grow and do better in life. As you take these calculated and necessary risks to move forward on your path to success, you build increased self-awareness as you learn more about yourself with each risk-taking exercise.

Taking smart risks requires you to be attuned to your capabilities and your limitations. Even if you take some risks without this knowledge, the outcomes and experience of the risk-taking exercise will help you build

self-awareness. So, with self-awareness, you can be better at taking risks. Either way, your emotional intelligence and self-motivation get a healthy boost.

Seeking feedback for improvement – The better you get at something, the more motivated you feel to try harder and achieve improved outcomes. One of the most efficient ways for self-improvement is by asking for feedback to enhance your productivity, efficiency, and the quality of your work.

Commitment to personal and professional goals – Commitment is one of the pillars of success. Whether you are motivated by extrinsic or intrinsic motivators, if you are committed to your personal and professional goals, you will achieve success in both places. With success comes increased motivation and confidence which, in turn, builds your self-awareness, conflict management skills, and finally emotional intelligence.

Actively seeking out and grabbing opportunities that help to achieve your goals – To do this, you must find the courage and personal empowerment. Courage does not translate to ‘absence of fear.’ A courageous person feels fear, and finds the resolve to overcome it, and take action when needed. In fact, many courageous people use fear to keep them grounded and prevent themselves from being carried away by overconfidence.

Courageous people are emotionally intelligent too because courage is needed to stand up and speak, and also to stand down and listen. Courage is that element that empowers you to take smart and calculated risks and take all the opportunities that come your way to achieve your goals. Courage is not doing something blindly but being aware of the risks, and after much thought and deliberation going ahead by overcoming fears.

Tips to Motivate Others

An emotionally intelligent person is not only self-motivated but can also motivate others to achieve their potential. Here are some tips to help you motivate others:

Listen – Listening skills are one of the most important pillars of emotionally intelligent people. They not only listen to their own feelings and thoughts but can also listen to the feelings and thoughts of other people through their enhanced and fine-tuned active listening skills. So, in order to motivate, you must first listen to what they want, and then show them how they can achieve their own needs.

Focus on open-ended questions – If you want to understand what the dreams and desires are of your loved ones at home or your team members at the office, then you must pose open-ended questions such as:

- What do you want to do?
- What do you dream of?
- How long have you been dreaming of this, and why?
- What excites and motivates you?

Encourage – This is the first active step from your end to start motivating your people. Most often, people are scared to work towards their dreams with the primary reason being the fear of failure. You must find encouraging words to motivate such people who are scared to follow their dreams. Tell them things like:

- I believe that your skills in this particular area will help you realize your dream.
- I believe you will be great at it. So, why don't you give it a shot, and give it your best shot? If you fail, at least you know you tried.

For example, if your daughter wants to start a pet store, and she is hesitant to quit her job (which she hates but unwittingly has converted it into a

crutch which she doesn't want to let go), tell her, 'I was watching you with our neighbor's dog. He seems to like you a lot even though I have seen him bark nastily at many other people. I believe you have a way with animals. Go ahead, give your dreams wings. Think about that pet shop you've always wanted to open. I'm sure you will be great at it. You are such a great worker that if you have any self-doubts midway, you can always get back to comfortable job.'

Teach them to dream – Let us take the 'pet shop' example again. You can tell your daughter, 'Imagine that cozy little place that people will love to bring their pets to shop. Imagine it becoming one of the most popular animal hangouts of the neighbors. When you have made sufficient money, you could look at expanding your business to have a nursery for animals to be left when their owners travel.' Let her visualize her dream. The more vivid her dream, the more motivated she will be to start implementing it.

Don't forget to offer help – Motivating others includes offering help. Ask people what you can do. Most of the time, if you have helped people find their spark, they really might not need anything else from you. However, offering to help is a way of re-instilling your faith in their capabilities.

Follow up – Very few people will listen to their heart's clarion call at your first attempt at motivation. If you truly believe in helping people reach their potential, then you must follow up with them, and ensure they make progress. This step is especially crucial when people encounter their first serious setback. Typically, at such times, they are bound to be filled with self-doubts and will need your encouragement.

Motivation is an element that is vital to keep your emotional intelligence high. The more motivated you feel, the more vitality you will have to support yourself and others through difficult times, knowing full well that success and happiness lie on the other side of hard work, commitment, and persistent efforts.

Chapter 8:

Emotional Intelligence and Social Skills

The phrase ‘social skills’ is a very broad term that is used in the context of emotional intelligence specifically to refer to skills needed to influence and handle other people’s emotions and feelings effectively, be a great leader, motivate others, and help others achieve their optimum potential.

Good social skills is an element that is often confused with being an extrovert. Well, a shy or introvert could have high levels of social awareness because this skill which is an important component of emotional intelligence having to do with the following abilities:

- To tune in and connect with the emotions of other people.
- To understand how others perceive or think about various things.
- To collaborate.
- To be a team player.
- To be good at negotiation skills.

Social skills in emotional intelligence cover many elements including:

- Influencing and persuasion skills
- Communication skills
- Conflict management skills
- Leadership skills
- Building rapport
- Team-working skills

All of the above skills can be learned and mastered during our lifetime. Social skills include those that cover personal, professional, and social relationships. Here are some tips to help build social skills to improve emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication.

Influencing and Persuasion

There are different ways to influence and persuade people. Here are some of them:

Nagging – Nagging is the ‘art’ of talking incessantly about your perspective that others are literally bullied into submission. It might work sometimes and in some places. At home, continuous bickering from either partner can compel the other partner to agree to something simply to get some peace of mind.

At the workplace, colleagues also could give in to the nagging of a peer simply because they are pushed into a corner. However, the thing here is that people have not really bought into the idea, and have been coerced into it making nagging totally contradictory to nonviolent communication.

Coercion – In coercion, people tend to use their position of power to get others to submit to their viewpoint. Here, too, colleagues and/or family members will most probably not like what they are doing, but due to other unavoidable pressures, they tend to surrender to coercion. Here, the people submit to the coercer’s ideas because they ‘have’ to, and not because they ‘want’ to.

Therefore, the right way to persuade is to let others know what is good for them, accept the idea wholeheartedly, and then gently convince them to take your viewpoint. Let us look at this illustration to understand how you can persuade people through nonviolent communication:

A team at an IT company was given a new project, and they had to choose a team leader amongst themselves. After much deliberation and discussion, it was decided that two people, Stan and Susan, are best suited for the job. Only one had to be the leader.

Stan turned to Susan and said, ‘You take on the job,’ and Susan happily consented. Everyone was happy with the decision except one person, Donald who was quiet until then.

When Susan accepted the role of team leader, Donald said, “Susan, please let us know our job descriptions and who is responsible for what task. You will have a lot of additional work, and you must make sure your team is perfectly organized so that we meet our milestones as per the needs of the clients. Please do let us know if you think tasks have to be reallocated if deadlines are not being met.”

Susan thought for a while, and said, “You know, I think it might be a better idea to let Stan take on the role as I might not really find the time and energy to do everything that is required by the team leader.” Everyone looked at Stan who agreed if the group also thought it would be a good idea. At this point, everyone agreed that Stan would be a better choice.

After the meeting was over, Stan called over Donald and asked him the reason for his intervention after the group had agreed on the decision of making Susan the team leader. Donald replied, “I believe you will make a better team leader than Susan.” So, very subtly, Donald used his persuasive skills by letting Susan know what she will have to manage if she chose to take on the role.

This subtle and nonviolent means of communication triggered the right thought process in Susan’s mind, and she quickly realized that she might not really fit the role. Therefore, Donald’s nonviolent means of persuasion helped create a win-win solution for everyone concerned without any residual bad blood in the team!

Communication Skills

Emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication hinge on the power of your communication skills. How do you define a good communicator? Here are a few indicators:

- Good communicators listen to everyone's concerns making every effort to understand others' needs.
- Good communicators are willing to listen to problems too. They are not overly focused only on the good things of life, and understand that the good and bad co-exist. They understand that problems will crop up, and they have to be countered.
- Good communicators don't put off unpleasant situations. They deal with problems quickly and effectively without allowing them to fester into irreparable wounds.
- Good communicators can quickly catch the emotional cues of other people, and respond appropriately keeping their own emotions well under control.

Conflict Management Skills

Another chapter in this book deals with conflict management in detail. However, briefly and in context to the topic of social skills, people with good conflict management skills know and acknowledge the importance of tact and diplomacy. People who are skilled in conflict management learn and master the art of diplomacy to diffuse difficult situations.

They bring out conflicts into the open so that more solutions are available to resolve them. They encourage airing and sharing of emotions in a dignified and respectful manner ensuring no one's feelings are hurt, and no one loses face. Effective conflict managers are those who work in tandem with the entire group to get optimal outcomes for everyone concerned.

Leadership Skills

Emotional intelligence and leadership skills are inextricably interlinked with each other. Good leaders have to necessarily have high levels of emotional intelligence. Only those who can cope with and manage their own emotions can influence and persuade others to follow their lead. After all, the key elements of a good leader are his or her ability to influence and persuade.

If you have noticed, when great leaders make a speech, the entire crowd is listening in rapt attention. Some people call this the ‘charisma’ of a leader; rationally speaking, this is nothing but outstanding levels of emotional intelligence. Indicators of a good leader include:

- The ability to articulate a vision so well that others are enthused by it.
- The ability to lead a group even if not in a formal leadership position.
- The ability to drive and support colleagues and family members to achieve their potential while teaching them to be accountable for their actions.
- The ability to lead by example.

Building Rapport

Building rapport is a critical element in maintaining strong relationships with people. People who build good rapport have a wide and robust social network. They have a long list of contacts and connections. The primary basis for rapport building is to value the contributions and opinions of others. Here are some tips based on nonviolent communication to show people you value them and build strong, long-lasting bonds:

Show interest in people – Ask people about themselves; what they like, what they dislike. You have to get to know people with whom you want to build long-lasting relationships with. What work do they do? Do they like their work? What are their passions? Build better bonds with people by showing interest in them and making efforts to know them well.

Give constructive feedback – Yes, when you see people you value making mistakes, it actually becomes your duty to warn them, and let them know they are doing wrong so that they can quickly correct themselves, and set things right. When people notice your concern about their welfare, they are bound to like you more and enhance their relationship with you.

Invest in their happiness – Find out what makes people you value happy, and invest your resources in creating situations that give them happiness. It doesn't have to be buying things for them. It could be something like spending time with someone who is lonely, lending your shoulder for someone to cry on, listening to their problems even if you cannot provide solutions. Investing in people's happiness will endear you to them, and help you build a strong rapport with them.

Be ready to let go – Sometimes, you have to let people go to show them that you genuinely value them, and care for their welfare. Here is a classic example; if you have a great team member who has been given an opportunity to move to a better position, you must be ready to let go of the person because that is a sign of high emotional intelligence. Holding on to people when they want to move is not the best way to show you care for them.

Team-Working Skills

Cooperating and collaboration form the backbone of nonviolent communication. An emotionally intelligent person values the importance of team-working skills. People with high emotional intelligence know and appreciate the fact that the people in a team are as important as the activity undertaken by it.

Emotionally strong people do not hesitate to share their ideas, thoughts, plans, and strategies with other team members so that the team as a whole achieves optimal success. When a team is filled with good team players, then the team more often than not achieves great success in all their endeavors.

Emotionally intelligent people can display their team working skills either from a position of a leader or as an ordinary team member.

How to Convert an Argument into a Productive Discussion

Converting an argument into a productive discussion is one of the best ways to build relationship skills at home, at the workplace, or in your social circle.

Let's take this scenario: Your partner has returned after a hectic day at the office. You are also tired at the end of the day trying to complete endless chores at home, helping your kids do their homework, and lots, lots more work. Your partner returns home, and finds his cozy corner on the sofa in front of the TV, and does not get up from there until bedtime. Even dinner happens there.

On that particular day, you are also completely enervated, and after dinner, the sight of the sink filled with dirty dishes to wash fills you with anger. You turn around and see your partner sitting in his comfy corner with no intention to help you out, and your anger breaches its limits.

“For the love of God, can you do the dishes at least this one day?” you scream at him. He screams back, “I am tired after a full day at work. You have it all easy sitting at home the whole day with not a care in the world! And you want me to do the dishes too?” And that's it, a full-blown argument sets in with nastiness thrown at each other and each other's families rattling the home leaving everyone depressed, angry, and hurt.

Emotionally intelligent people will not take this route at all. Here is what you can do to build improved relationship skills at home and at your workplace using nonviolent communication:

First, observe and deal with your emotions – When you know that you are ready to get into a full-blown fight with your partner, step away from the situation, take a moment to first deal with your emotion which is invariably anger in such situations. When you take time out, you are also giving time to the other person to deal with his or her emotions.

Find some alone time, and focus on your emotion by identifying and labeling it. Indulge in something that you know helps you bring down the intensity of the emotional energy. You can go for a walk, listen to your favorite music, call someone you trust to talk about your frustrations or anything else. Once the emotional energy has calmed down, then come back to solve the problem.

In a long-standing, it is actually possible for both partners to know each other's stress-handling mechanisms (by the way, even in new relationships, one of the first things you need to know about each other is how you handle negative emotions; an aspect that is sadly given the least importance).

So, if your words are, 'I am going for a walk. We'll continue after a while,' then your spouse might get the hint that you need time to cool off. He can also use this time to reflect on what happened, and manage his emotions so that when both of you are sitting down again, the argument mood has evaporated. Instead, an atmosphere of open discussion has set in.

Now, another point of caution here. Sometimes, actually quite often, when our emotions calm down after the relaxing break, we generally get into a misconceived notion that everything's fine. But, remember the root cause of the emotion is still unresolved. If you ignore it now, it is bound to relapse repeatedly, and each time with greater intensity than before. Know this, and get back for the discussion with your spouse to eliminate the persistent problem.

Now, discuss the problem – With the emotion taken care for the moment, you can approach the problem rationally and objectively. What are your needs and what are the needs of your spouse? Are these needs in conflict with each other? To arrive at answers for such questions, you must choose your battles sensibly.

For example, in the above case wherein the sink full of dirty dishes may have been the trigger for your angry outburst, think again and ask yourself what the underlying need is? Do you need more attention or love or quality

time from your husband? Use these thoughts to start the discussion with your husband.

For example, doing dirty dishes might not be a sensible battle if you know deep down that your underlying need is that it has been more than a month since the two of you have spent quality time together. So, that should be the point of discussion with your husband. Alternately, are you concerned that your husband is becoming increasingly lazy? Therefore, think and choose your battle before starting the discussion.

Just remember that your husband also has had time to reflect on his actions, and it is quite likely that he could voice his concerns which might need you to think again. The trick is in converting an argumentative phase into a collaborative, productive, useful, and worthy discussion.

An argument indicates one versus the other whereas a discussion indicates finding common ground. In an argument, participants take opposing stands fighting each other down whereas, in a discussion, partners work side by side, and solve problems to find compatible and optimal solutions that are good for both. In a discussion, both sides are open to hearing the concerns of the other which, in turn, helps in creating a pathway that is responsive to the concerns raised by both sides.

Many times, the expression of the emotion is enough for the other person to learn, and ensure not to repeat things that hurt the speaker. For example, 'I feel ignored if you don't put down your mobile at the dinner table.' An emotionally intelligent partner will make sure he or she never brings the device to the dining table. It's an easy solution for a seemingly difficult problem.

Have follow-up action – For example, if both of you have decided to spend more quality time with each other, then, have an action to ensure this happens. Are you planning a dinner or movie regularly? Just make sure the plans are realistic. For instance, if you decide that you will go out every week, it might not be possible if the working partner keeps really long hours, and sometimes, even has to work on weekends. Instead, start off with

something as simple as spending Sunday afternoons with each other or at least with family and friends where both of you will be present.

The same process will work in a professional environment too. Simply replace your partner with your co-workers, team members, bosses, or other important people at your workplace, and use the same process to increase your social awareness and skills which, in turn, will raise your emotional intelligence a few notches up.

Emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication skills are most evident in a person's social skills. But, social skills are neither the beginning nor the end of emotional intelligence which is more cyclical in nature. You start with self-awareness, build self-management skills, develop empathy, grow motivation levels, all of which help in expanding your social skills. With improved social skills resulting in a strong and wide circle of robust relationships in your personal and professional life, your self-awareness is bound to improve, setting the cycle moving again.

Chapter 9:

Making Assumptions, Vulnerability, and Emotional Intelligence

A newly-wed couple high-flying couple, Maria and John, have just moved into their new home. After a wonderful honeymoon, both have got back to their hectic, stressed jobs; Maria was a lawyer working for a prestigious firm in the city, and John was a successful investment banker.

One day, John and Maria were both focused on their respective laptops deeply engrossed in their own work. Dinner was done, and both had a couple of hours of work to complete before they could call it a day. Suddenly, John looked up from this computer, and said, ‘I have this important presentation to complete, and I am a bit nervous because it is a huge client for the bank. Can you tell me what you think of this closing?’ Maria responds, ‘Hmm-huh.’

John starts reading, and Maria continues to keep her eyes focused on her laptop. After reading for a minute, John looks up, and in a curt voice asks Maria, ‘Are you even listening to what I am reading?’ Maria looks up too, and says, ‘Of course I am.’ An emotionally intelligent couple will typically avoid this kind of a situation. Let us analyze it. If you look closely, both John and Maria made a lot of assumptions including:

- John assumed Maria would immediately turn her focus on to him when he first raised his head to talk to her.
- Maria assumed that her ‘Hmm-huh’ was enough to let him know that she was ready.
- John assumed that just because Maria was not looking at him, she was not listening.
- Maria assumed that John knew she could multitask and could do her own work while being able to focus on what John was saying.

- Both of them assumed that their body language cues were not important in the communication process.

Assumptions, Emotional Intelligence, and Nonviolent Communication

Making assumptions is the antithesis to nonviolent communication and emotional intelligence. Yet, why do most of us fall into the trap of making assumptions? Here are some easy-to-understand reasons:

- Making assumptions is easy.
- A little bit of incomplete information is all that is needed to start off making assumptions.
- It is far more difficult to ask questions and get the complete information, and so we avoid getting into this activity.
- When information is incomplete, we fill up the blanks with our own assumptions and our own interpretations of the data that we have in our hands.

We simply combine the incomplete data with our own past experiences and end up creating something that could be quite contrary to the actual situation. We put and connect dots in places where actually there are no dots. And, we justify ourselves for this action because we don't have the full information, and remember we didn't want to make an effort to ask questions and seek out all relevant data. Therefore, we make up connections that don't exist and leave out connections that exist. Evidently, the conclusions are all going to be skewed.

Recall your first driving lessons. Here is a typical scenario of such as a situation. You are driving on the road, and you need to turn left. You see the rearview mirror and notice a car at the back. You quickly assume the driver of that car is going to turn left because you are turning left. But, the driver does something different. If you had given a second's thought to the situation, you would have seen that the other had his right indicator on!

And thus, assumptions are formed! And, if rational matters can create horrible accidents resulting in physical pain, assumptions of the emotional kind can create extreme mental agony and pain. Why? Because emotions come with multiple sensory buttons that will trigger and refresh the pain of

past experiences too. Emotional pain will touch every nerve that carries memories of pain, and you will feel you are reliving all the old experiences afresh.

Assumptions have the power to lash out at people wittingly or not, and you will also feel the toxicity. Unfair assumptions will hurt the mind first which will then find its way to physical symptoms and chronic issues and will result in long-term health disorders. Assumptions are obstacles to displaying compassion which is the core strength and power of nonviolent communication.

Here are some excellent reasons as to why making assumptions can be counterproductive to nonviolent communication:

They are an easy and lazy way out – Anything that comes easy is rarely substantial, and more often than not, has no real value. It might serve as a reprieve. But, the outcomes of easy routes will come back to haunt you with accumulated energy.

The lack of motivation to ask the right questions to learn the right things is primarily driven by laziness; an attitude that can only harm you. The more you use assumptions to do things, the more of a habit it will become, and you will find it increasingly difficult to learn and grow out from that stagnation.

Assumptions prevent you from taking responsibility for your actions – Nonviolent communication can be useful for individuals and the world at large only when each of us takes responsibility for our actions, behaviors, and thoughts. Assumptions allow you to hide behind your side of the story, and when that flimsy curtain falls, you are bound to face the consequences of wrong conclusions. Assumptions make you believe that others are to blame for your problems; an approach that will never help you set your life straight.

Assumptions keep you in the past – Typically, your assumptions are based on reading incomplete data along with your past experiences. Therefore,

making assumptions always keep your outlook stuck in the past instead of looking forward and broadening your horizons.

Moreover, your old negative mindset will cement itself into your psyche, and you will never learn to look at things from a new perspective, one of the most important elements for emotional intelligence. If you cannot see others' views, you will never build your emotional intelligence.

Assumptions are toxic habits – We make assumptions to prevent feeling hurt. And to hide this hurt, we invariably lash out at others using violence and hate to cover our insecurities and fears. Therefore, assumptions lead to endless toxicity in your life.

Assumptions result in wrong judgments and choices – Making decisions based on assumptions is a sure way to do the wrong things in life. Assumptions are not facts, and therefore, decisions made from assumptions will not stand strong.

Even personal decisions based on assumptions might come in the way of achieving your dreams and goals. For example, if you love traveling, and but assume that travel comes with dangers, then you are never going to achieve your dream of traveling the world. Instead of assuming that travel is dangerous, you must sit down and find out solid facts on what problems travelers encounter and how they overcome it. Then, work your travel plans around these facts, and you will see that your assumption was holding you down needlessly.

Assumptions drive you to pick at your old pains repeatedly. The more you pick at the old wounds, the more they will fester, and the more pain you will feel. It is best to let the old wounds heal, and make an effort to see things accurately and correctly possibly by asking questions and increasing your knowledge. Grow beyond your assumptions.

Vulnerability, Emotional Intelligence, and Nonviolent Communication

Being vulnerable is being exposed to the risks of danger. For example, if you have not insured your home against risks such as floods and burglaries, then your home is ‘vulnerable’ to those risks. However, in the world of emotional intelligence, vulnerability is something quite different.

Brene Brown, the research professor who has studied the ideas of courage, shame, vulnerability, and empathy for over two decades, says that vulnerability is neither good nor bad. It is not positive or negative. She says that to be vulnerable is to feel. If you deny vulnerability, then you deny feeling. ‘To close the world of feelings driven by a fear that the costs far outweigh the benefits is to walk away from the very purpose and meaning of our life. Human life is meant to feel,’ Brene Brown says in her book, ‘Daring Greatly.’

Vulnerability is empowering and liberating in the path of nonviolent communication. This may sound strange to many of us considering how the attitude of vulnerability is quite often taken to be associated with weakness which can be easily exploited by other people around us.

However, in truth, showing your vulnerability has multiple benefits, and most importantly, it allows you to be truly and wholly authentic. Being prepared to display your vulnerability gives you the power to show who you truly are without having to put on facades. You are free from having to put on a show in front of people pretending to be someone else instead of who you really are.

Brene Brown says, ‘The display of vulnerability is the most accurate measure of courage.’ She says that we must move vulnerability from the point of weakness to a source of strength. Why is it good for your emotional intelligence to display vulnerability? Here are a few reasons:

Vulnerability improves your self-awareness – Accepting your vulnerabilities openly helps you embrace your weaknesses and quirks

wholeheartedly. When you accept what is commonly seen as ‘awkward’ characteristics, the awkwardness disappears, and in its place, you find something that defines your uniqueness. The more you engage with yourself in this manner, the more your self-awareness grows. And the more your self-awareness grows, the more emotionally intelligent you become.

Vulnerability builds intimacy – One of the biggest benefits of being vulnerable is that it allows you to build great intimacy with your partner. Psychological experts have come to believe that in romantic relationships, both partners have a mutual need for nurturing. They take turns to be the caretaker and caregiver in various situations. And this can happen only when both express their needs by showing their vulnerability to each other. Falling in love with the intention of building a long-lasting romantic relationship is the ultimate test for vulnerability.

Vulnerability improves your self-worth – Admitting your vulnerability and sense of shame to yourself and to other people helps in increasing your self-worth because you accept yourself for what you are including warts and all. Your self-acceptance frees you from the need to compare yourself with others empowering you to show your uniqueness without feeling shame. All of this leads to improved self-worth.

Vulnerability facilitates innovation and motivation – Each time you raise your voice to give an idea at the workplace, you are effectively displaying your vulnerability because you are exposing your idea to both ridicule and praise. Notwithstanding the outcome of your ideas, you are creating an environment of engaging innovation and motivation for others to bring out their ideas as well.

Any company that allows its employees to express their concerns and problems transparently is helping in creating an environment conducive for personal and professional growth. Display of vulnerability among team members increases bonhomie and sense of oneness as everyone relates to each other’s problems.

Vulnerability promotes compassion – When you see vulnerability, most human beings feel a deep sense of compassion for the person. When you see someone else's display of negative emotions that potentially end in shame, you are bound to feel a sense of understanding and will reach out to comfort and empathize with them. Similarly, when others see your vulnerability, they are moved to compassion towards you. Therefore, the display of vulnerability promotes compassion in human beings; a critical component of nonviolent communication.

Vulnerability helps you come to terms with past troubled memories – Opening up about your weaknesses and problems will help you deal with unresolved trauma from your past. Confronting and accepting what happened in the past is the best way of overcoming the pains associated with it. You will find it easy to accept your bad decisions, wrong choices, etc. and accept your mistakes without being judgmental and harsh on yourself. Vulnerability promotes self-compassion too; an essential element to be compassionate to and empathize with others.

Vulnerability empowers you to take responsibility for your actions and behaviors – When you admit your mistakes openly in public, you are telling people that you are ready to take responsibility for your behaviors and want to take corrective action.

You are telling people that you accept the fact that the source of your problems is only you, and no one else is to be blamed for what is happening in your life. This approach helps you get rid of the fear of expressing yourself honestly and openly which, in turn, helps you take control of your life in your hands.

Vulnerability helps to keep loneliness at bay – By pretending to be invulnerable, you are putting up a phony façade which increases in intensity with each passing day. Sooner or later, people will realize and detect your inauthenticity even as they pretend to sympathize with you and your fake behavior. This hollow relationship will lead to increased levels of discomfort between you and others taking us further away from people and

driving loneliness. You will be keeping this kind of loneliness at bay when you accept and display your vulnerability to all.

Vulnerability brings the right kind of people into your life – When you are open about your true self, only the ones who can relate with the kind of person you are will make an effort to create lifelong relationships with you. This way, you can rest assured that the right kind of people will become your lifelong, trustworthy friends.

Making assumptions and being vulnerable are closely connected to emotional intelligence. The fewer assumptions you make and the more vulnerable you choose to be, the more emotionally intelligent you will become; all thanks to the fact that these two elements contribute significantly to building compassion, becoming more self-aware, increasing motivation, and more such concepts connected with nonviolent communication.

Chapter 10:

Emotional Intelligence in Conflict Resolution

Conflicts are one of the most common aspects of human life. You will find them in your home, workplace, among friends, in society, in politics, and everywhere else where human beings exist. Conflicts occur because people tend to disagree with each other.

A critical outcome of any unresolved conflict is that it can lead to bullying. Identifying and resolving conflicts everywhere are essential components to prevent the situation from becoming uncontrolled by bullying and trolling among the disagreeing parties.

Timely conflict management and resolution lead to multiple benefits including goal accomplishment, strengthening relationships, improving leadership skills, and more. If left unresolved or if conflicts are mismanaged, they can quickly turn into dislike and even hatred.

Unresolved conflicts are the primary reason for relationships to break down. Most of the time, unresolved conflicts end up in bullying by the people who seem to hold higher power over the less fortunate people resulting in discontentment which, in turn, can lead to a lot of unpleasantness.

Multiple studies have proven that unresolved social conflicts are one of the primary causes of the outbreak and spread of terrorism; an element that is rocking our world today. Therefore, managing and resolving conflicts are not just important for personal and professional success but also have to be taken up on priority for the good of all humankind.

How Emotional Intelligence Helps in Conflict Management

Here are some ways how emotionally intelligent people are able to manage conflicts better than those who have low levels of EQ:

Increased self-awareness - Emotionally intelligent people do not indulge in unproductive conflicts because of their high levels of self-awareness. Being self-aware means you know your emotions and thoughts very well which means you can recognize your moods.

And, if you are not feeling particularly good about things in life, you will avoid situations with potential for conflicts. Instead, you will deliberately indulge in productive activities that take you towards improving your moods.

Emotionally intelligent people not only have increased self-awareness but also have good control over their feelings, and will not let their emotions ride them. Therefore, even if they are caught in the middle of an unpleasant situation while they are in a bad mood, then too, emotionally intelligent will handle it with care, and ensure conflicts are either avoided or amicably resolved.

Increased access to innovative solutions – Conflicts and disputes are actually good for a brainstorming session. In such situations, emotionally intelligent people will embrace conflicts and disagreements within their teams for effective brainstorming of ideas. They only ensure that the disagreements are kept at dignified levels by ensuring that no one in the team feels excessively abused or overwhelmed by others. Therefore, emotionally intelligent people don't always avoid conflict; they just manage them productively.

Increased ability to manage behavior – Sometimes, with the best of intentions, even emotionally intelligent fall prey to nasty conflicts. The difference between people with high EQ and those with low EQ is that emotionally intelligent people know how to manage their emotions and their behaviors rooted in those emotions.

Even in the most unpleasant circumstances including those that result in failures, people with high EQs behave with dignity and respect. They accept defeat with humility and victories and great moments don't define their emotional intelligence; their ability to identify, manage, and control emotion defines their EQ.

Thus, emotional intelligence plays a crucial role in conflict resolution. And yet, conflicts are something most of us would like to avoid considering the huge levels of discomfort and unpleasantness that they bring in their wake. Here are some excellent NVC-based techniques to help you resolve and manage conflicts:

Use Words Effectively to State Your Feelings

Here is a typical scenario between spouses. The husband returns home after a hectic day and is dying to share his problems with his wife. When he reaches home, he notices that his wife is watching her favorite series on TV. Without even a preamble, he starts ranting about how bad the day was, and his wife seems to be nodding at his comments.

Soon, the husband loses his cool, and screams at his wife, “Here I am coming home after working so hard at the office, and you don’t even want to listen to me!” The wife turns to him taking her attention off from the TV, and appears quite shocked at his reaction and says, “Of course, I am listening to you. I have heard every word you said. You don’t have to be so angry at me. I also was busy the entire day looking after the home, and have got time only now to relax!”

Can you notice the beginning of a conflict? As you read, you can clearly discern the choice of words used in this situation that is creating the conflict. The husband makes it sound like as if he is blaming his wife for his office problems, and the wife seems to say that she is not interested in listening because she has issues of her own. Now, let us take the 4-step NVC process in this situation see how emotionally intelligent people will act. In this example, let us suppose the wife has high levels of emotional intelligence.

Step 1: Observation –The husband is walking into the house and the wife who was watching her favorite series switches off the TV. She smiles at her husband, and she notices that he gives her a perfunctory nod. He looks tired and haggard too. She helps him off with his coat and makes him a nice hot cup of tea or coffee. Her observation skills are good enough to be able to discern that her husband has a need that requires attention.

Step 2: Feelings – As the husband sips his coffee, she sits next to him, and asks him, “How are you feeling?” Notice that she does not ask him, “How did the day go?” because her focus is on his feelings and not the situation.

Step 3: Needs – Of course, her husband responds, “I’m feeling horrible.” Now, she turns to him, holds his hand, and asks him, “Why are you feeling horrible? Did something or someone upset you in your office?”

Steps 4: Requests – “Would you like to talk about it?”

The same situation as earlier, just a few tweaks in reactions and responses, and the conflict was avoided even before it started. The choice of words used by the emotionally intelligent wife had no blame. It was only an assurance to her husband that she is there to give him comfort.

Understand Before Trying to Be Understood

One of the most significant reasons for conflicts is the desire to be understood before trying to understand. If you constantly want to be right, then it means you are not ready to listen to the other person's point of view. Therefore, first try to understand the other person, and then you can put your viewpoint.

For this, you must build excellent listening skills. Let us look at some ways to build listening skills which will help build nonviolent communication skills:

Explain your understanding by summarizing and paraphrasing – Summarizing and paraphrasing are excellent tools to diffuse conflicts while increasing the understanding of an idea by everyone on the group. So, for example, if your husband keeps ranting about the bad day in the office for over five minutes, you can summarize his feelings like this, “So, you are frustrated about what happened in the office today because your boss didn't listen to you at all. You would like it if your boss considered your opinion, and gave you reasons why it is not a sound idea for the moment, right?”

Maintain eye contact during the conversation – It is important that the speaker knows that you are really listening to what he or she is saying. Maintaining good eye contact throughout the conversation is one of the best ways to tell the speaker know you are all ears. Of course, don't stare at the speaker; just maintain healthy eye contact.

Ask open questions – Another excellent way to let the other person know that you are trying to understand his or her ideas is by asking open questions. Instead of simply responding with monosyllables like ‘Hmm,’ or ‘yes’ or ‘no,’ you should ask questions like, “Why are you feeling bad about what happened?” Open questions foster longer and more engaged conversations than otherwise.

Use appropriate body language – Use body language techniques such as mirroring to show that you are listening and want to understand the other

person's perspective. Another chapter in this book discusses the importance of and various methods of body language communication in detail where you can read more about mirroring techniques.

It is imperative that you listen not just to put on a façade for the sake of the speakers but to truly understand their perspectives with which you can diffuse and resolve conflicts.

Understand and Appreciate Differences in Perspectives

Simply because you see things in a certain perspective does not mean other viewpoints don't have value. Everyone comes from different cultures, backgrounds, growing environments, etc.; all of which impact perspectives. People can see the same thing in different ways, and most of the ways have seemingly 'right' and 'wrong' perspectives.

Conflict resolution calls for finding common ground, and not arguments about who is right and who is wrong. Here are some classic examples of how accepting different perspectives help in our learning process:

Half-full or half-empty glass – Perhaps, one of the most common examples of different viewpoints. An optimist sees the glass as being half-full and shows gratitude for the good things of life. A pessimist sees the glass half-empty and complains about the missing things in life. It is important to lead an increasingly 'half-full' life so that we find the power to see the good in all which will help us arrive at common ground; an essential component of conflict resolution.

Things are not always what they appear – A beggar on the street is happier with a man who gave him \$20 and sends more blessings to him than to a man who gives him only \$10. What the beggar couldn't see was that the second man had only \$10 which he gave away to someone he believed needed more than him whereas the first man had \$2000 with him from which he was able to easily part with \$20. Therefore, things are not necessarily as they seem. A bit more delving needs to be done to get increasingly correct viewpoints.

One man's waste is another man's treasure – Remember those dandelions in our gardens? As children, we were delighted to see them because, in our innocent minds, these dandelions represented opportunities to make wishes. It didn't matter to us whether these wishes were realistic or not. The joy of making that wish was incomparable.

The same dandelions are seen as weeds by gardeners and landscapers. They would not be delighted but annoyed at seeing these 'weeds' which are spoiling the beauty of the garden or landscape.

Multiple solutions exist for the same problem – Most often, life problems including conflict resolution have more than one solution. Choosing a path that works for all is the right way to resolve and diffuse conflicts.

See the big picture - The world is big and full of people experiencing different things. Many times, we are so caught up with our own experiences that we forget other people are going through their own good and bad experiences. Billions of new experiences are being created each minute in this world, and each experience is different from the other. Each of us is only a speck in the huge, mighty world. This bigger picture helps us put ourselves in perspective and keeps us grounded too.

Learning from each of these perspectives helps us find multiple solutions to resolve and diffuse conflicts in ways that make everyone happy.

Focus on Impact and Not on Intent

How many times have people told you that what you said hurt them? You might never have intended to hurt, but the impact of your communication ended up creating hurt and pain. People who interact with you don't see your intent as much as they see the impact of what you are saying or doing.

Here is an example of how intent is not as important as impact in your communication. Suppose you are standing in a park reading messages on your mobile, and a frisbee hits you on your nose. Holding your bloody nose, you are spewing expletives on the thrower of the frisbee, a young girl.

She comes to you and says, "I am sorry it was not my intent to break your nose with my frisbee. I only wanted to throw it to my friend who is standing there." Aren't you ready to take that frisbee and throw it on your face, and say the same thing? You don't really care about her intent. But, the impact was tremendous, and you are not going to forgive her soon.

If you said something to your wife that hurts her, it does not matter what your intent was. She is hurting, that's it. Therefore conflict resolution has a lot to do with the impact of your communication and less to do with your intent. So, focus on the impact rather than the intent.

Maintain Dignity of Everyone Involved

Dignity and credibility play an important role in conflict management. Human beings are hardwired to treat shame the way as a physical wound. When our value or worth is threatened, we get into fight/flight mode just like the way we behave with physical dangers. Dignity is such an important need for human beings that the slightest threat to it can result in strong, and even violent, responses.

We love being connected with other human beings. But, our need for dignity is equally important. Which is why playing the dignity card sensitively is very important for effective conflict resolution. One place that you can find dignity trampled upon ruthlessly is during a bitter, nasty divorce. The agony of a broken relationship can drive anyone to inflict pain on the other partner.

Dignity and respect are fragile aspects of humankind, and it is one of the easiest elements to break down and create conflicts. The ten elements of dignity as explained by Donna Hicks in her book, *Leading with Dignity*, include the following acceptance of identity, recognition, acknowledgment, inclusion, safety, fairness, independence, understanding, giving people the benefit of the doubt, and accountability. Let us look at each one of these elements, and how they help in resolving and reducing conflicts.

Acceptance of identity – Treating everyone as being an equal is the first step to creating a sense of identity for them. It is important to approach everybody you meet with neither a superior or inferior complex. Each of us has the right to express our personality without fears of being ridiculed or judged negatively.

The first step to giving dignity is to treat everyone without prejudices based on gender, religion, race, culture, age, disability or sexual orientation. In such situations, conflicts can be easily resolved.

Recognition – All of us want to receive recognition for our work and our talents. Therefore, giving recognition to others for their ideas, help,

thoughtfulness, contributions, and hard work helps in creating a sense of dignity for everyone which, in turn, reduces conflicts among people.

Acknowledgment – People want to feel acknowledged. Listening, validating, and responding to people's problems and concerns make them feel acknowledged. This approach makes people believe in your ability to resolve conflicts favorably and without prejudice.

Inclusion – Being left out of any community or group results in a feeling of isolation which can affect one's dignity negatively. Therefore, as a conflict resolver, including all stakeholders and making them feel like they belonged will help in clearing up misunderstandings and apprehensions.

Safety – The feeling of safety is associated at two levels; physical and psychological. For a person to feel dignified, he or she must feel safe at both these levels. When you treat people in a way that makes them feel secure, then they will speak up freely and fearlessly instead of hiding their needs behind their fears which can help in resolving conflicts.

Fairness – All people within a framework should be treated equally and in an even-handed manner as per the rules and regulations within that particular framework. This approach ensures everyone feels comforted that their concerns are as important as other people's concerns and will be solved with equal intensity.

Independence – People must feel that they are in control of their lives to do what they wish to do. This sense of independence renders hope which, in turn, motivates people to come together and resolve disputes and conflicts.

Understanding – Understanding other perspectives is a crucial element for conflict resolution. When you make efforts to understand someone else's point of view, the person feels a sense of dignity that makes him or her feel empowered to participate in the conflict resolution process.

The benefit of the doubt – Don't treat people as if they are not trustworthy. Always give them the benefit of the doubt, and begin any conflict

negotiation process with the faith that everyone concerned has integrity and good motives.

Accountability – It is important to take accountability for all your actions. If for some reason, you have violated the dignity of another person, then you must accept your mistake and apologize for the same. Conflict resolution can happen only when people commit to changing themselves from hurtful behaviors.

At the end of this particular point, it is important to make a note of the fact that you must also maintain your decency and dignity to gain respectability in the community. If you don't get the dignity you deserve, it is unlikely you will find the strength to give dignity and bring warring teams together to the conflict resolution table.

Conflicts are not going to go away. There will always be disagreements in all aspects of our lives. With increased emotional intelligence, we can build the necessary skills to diffuse and resolve conflicts to positively impact our lives and those of everyone with whom we interact; at the workplace, at home, and in social circles.

Chapter 11:

The Role of Emotional Intelligence for a Healthy Professional Life

How does emotional intelligence (EQ) affect workplace performance and bottom lines of businesses and companies? To reiterate, emotionally intelligent people are able to:

- Identify, recognize, and discern their own emotions and behaviors.
- Identify, recognize, and discern other people's moods and behaviors.
- Manage and control their emotions and behaviors to demonstrate appropriate and compassionate responses as per the situation, more so in difficult and stressful situations.
- Demonstrate both genuine, honest feelings as well as socially accepted behavior like politeness, courtesy, respect, and consideration for everyone concerned.
- Resolve conflicts amicably.
- Demonstrate empathy toward others.

Emotionally intelligent people also understand and appreciate the importance of avoiding procrastination, self-doubt, low self-esteem, etc. Professionals with high levels of emotional intelligence know the value of work-life balance.

EQ, Personality, and Intelligent Quotient

EQ and Personality - To understand how and why EQ is important for a healthy workplace environment, let us start with the difference between EQ and personality. Psychologically speaking, the personality is defined as the behavioral, emotional, and thought patterns of an individual. The personality of an individual affects his or her personal preferences and tendencies such as the person prefer being an introvert or an extrovert.

Knowing your personality can help you distinguish your unique and special characteristic features. For example, if you take a personality test, you might know how open you are, what level of agreeableness you have, whether you are an extrovert or introvert, etc. However, these tests will never throw up how deeply ambitious you are which is independent of the personality traits. An introverted person can be as much as or, perhaps even more, ambitious than an extrovert.

A person who comes across as melancholic most of the times could be nursing and working towards achieving deep desires and ambitions backed by his or her inner strength and capabilities while a bubbly, confident, and happy person could be hiding his or her vulnerabilities for fear of ridicule or being 'left out' of the milieu.

Another example to illustrate the importance of EQ over personality; an extrovert could be highly suitable for a sales job. However, his or her level of persistence, drive, the ability to bounce back from failures, and hard work that are extremely critical elements for a sales job cannot be gauged through studying the personality of the individual.

On the other hand, a person with a high level of emotional intelligence can control and manage his impulses, adapt to changes efficiently, communicate compassionately and effectively with other people, etc. An emotionally intelligent person can do and be everything else needed for success in his profession, irrespective of his or personality type.

Let us look at this scenario: A second-hand car showroom has two men, Nathan and Stewart, working in the sales department. Nathan is an extrovert and is able to convince his customers to buy cars quickly. His first-visit conversion rate is nearly 90%; thanks to his convincing and outgoing attitude that endears many of his customers to him the first time they meet them, and with his amazing sales pitch, he is able to convince that the car he has chosen for them is the best buy.

However, there is a lot of other work that goes on after the customer decides to buy the car. Documents from the customer have to be collected, the vehicle will have to be registered to the new owner's name. Loan documents, if any, need to be completed. Nathan may be an extrovert. But, he lacked persistence, commitment, and other important traits needed to finish the work that follows a successful sale.

The profits for the showroom come only when the customer makes the final payment, and the circle of the sale is completed in all respects. So, even though Nathan was able to convince customers to buy the car on the first visit, his follow-up work needed a lot more improvement because of which his actual conversion rate rarely crossed 40%.

Contrarily, Stewart is more of an introvert. He took his time to analyze his customers, what their needs and requirements are, and what their likes and dislikes are before proposing a suitable vehicle for them. Then, they would patiently and slowly take them through the advantages and disadvantages. Stewart would never try to sell a vehicle he knows will not be managed by the buyer.

For example, if he can gauge that the customer is looking for a good, sturdy car for his daily needs with minimal maintenance issues, then he would not even consider showing him a high-end luxury car. He would show them all the models that are aligned with the customer's needs. Stewart's biggest advantage is to follow up with his customers to make sure the transaction is complete in all respects; documents, insurance, registration, etc.

Stewart was an emotionally intelligent individual even though his lack of salesman flashiness could fool the average manager. Luckily for him, the owner of the showroom, Mr. Smith, was able to gauge and understand the quiet strength of Stewart. Of course, he liked Nathan's gregariousness. But, he was well aware of Nathan's lack of depth in terms of emotional intelligence.

With his own high levels of EQ, Mr. Smith was able to complement the personalities, strengths, and weaknesses of his two salesmen, and ensure his company's bottom lines were also good which, in turn, helped him to take care of his employees well.

EQ and intelligent quotient – Intelligent quotient (IQ) represents the following abilities of an individual:

- Knowledge of the world
- Quantitative analysis
- Reasoning capabilities
- Spatial and visual processing capabilities
- Short-term and long-term memories

Until recently, the IQ of a person was considered to be the primary determinant of a person's success. Students who had a high IQ score were believed to be destined for success while those with low IQ scores were destined for failures. However, researchers did come up with plenty of success stories in which real-life protagonists had low IQs. Here are some examples of people with IQs who went on to change the history of mankind through their thoughts and discoveries:

Abraham Lincoln – Yes, this man of vision is known to have had a low IQ, and yet, that didn't deter him from changing the course of American history forever.

Andy Warhol – This legendary pop art icon is believed to have had an IQ score of 86!

John F. Kennedy – His IQ was supposed to be as low as 60! The amount of work he did and the success he achieved hardly reflected this low score.

Dr. James Watson and Dr. Francis Crick – They are famous as the Watson-Crick duo, the brainy scientists and Nobel Prize winners who first postulated the structure of the human DNA. Yes, both of them had low IQ scores!

E.O. Wilson – Another scientist, naturalist, biologist, and a Pulitzer Prize winner, E.O. Wilson is a leading world expert on the study of ants, myrmecology. His success is not backed by a high IQ at all; but sheer hard work, determination, and a never-say-die attitude.

These are just a handful of examples. Many times, you don't need to look at people who have achieved world success to realize the truth that high IQ scores do not guarantee, and low IQ scores need not worry you at all. Today, multiple research studies and surveys conducted all across the world have proven that emotional intelligence, empathy, and compassion are far more important elements for success than IQ.

The Five EQ Components at the Workplace

Here are the five components of emotional intelligence and how each of them contributes to creating a positive environment in the workplace driving both business and camaraderie.

Social Skills

An emotionally intelligent individual displays multiple social competencies including empathy, diplomacy, political acumen, and intuition all of which are very useful in the workplace to improve efficiency and productivity.

Intuition and empathy help you in the following ways:

For improved understanding of other people's feelings and perception-

A well-developed intuition helps you to sense and understand your colleagues and team members' perspectives and feelings. You can use these powers to demonstrate genuine concern and active interests in their work. This approach helps you build strong relationships with everyone in the office thereby creating an environment of bonhomie and camaraderie; a critical element for increased productivity and efficiency.

Increased customer service orientation – Your ability to preempt, identify, and meet customer needs will get a big boost when your intuition and empathy skills are sharpened. Meeting and exceeding customer requirements is the cornerstone of the success of any business or profession.

Improved people management skills – Your intuitive and empathetic skills will develop your people management skills as you will find it increasingly easy to connect two similar-thinking people and put them together to create a team that resonates with success.

Also, like Mr. Smith, the owner of the second-hand car showroom in the example cited above, you will find ways and methods to mix together two seemingly different personalities but those whose strengths and weaknesses complement resulting again in great teams. This approach helps you leverage the power of diversity for optimum outcomes.

Moreover, your ability to read your team's needs and desires will help you help them achieve their full potential so that they can grow and develop.

Diplomacy and political acumen will help you achieve success at the workplace in the following ways:

Influence over others – Your persuasive tactics based on compassion for all stakeholders will help you influence others in the organization and business partners and help you achieve your desired results. Your ability to build long-term connections will help you nurture relationships; a key skill for sustained professional success.

Clear communication style –Diplomacy and political acumen bring with them the power of a clear and unambiguous communication style that will send convincing messages understood by everyone concerned. Clear communication styles backed by diplomacy, political acumen, and empathy will increase your capabilities to resolve conflicts.

Leadership skills – You will be able to lead and guide people to achieve your business goals even as they realize their personal dreams of success. With your ability to lead, you can make a tremendous impact in bringing about sustained positive changes within your organization.

Improved cooperation and collaboration capabilities – You will bring together and synergize people with different skills and competencies so that everyone is working towards shared goals. This synergy among the team members will increase team capabilities far more significantly than if individuals were working on their own.

Self-Awareness

Being aware of your strengths, weaknesses, and limitations will help you in the following ways at your workplace:

Helps you manage your emotional responses - Increased emotional awareness will help you manage your responses and reactions to ensure others are impacted optimally in a positive way and negative impacts from your emotions are kept to a minimum. This situation will ensure that your colleagues and coworkers find you approachable and will come to you to give and take help.

Helps you get an accurate assessment of your skill set - An accurate assessment of your skills and weaknesses will help you understand which areas you can work on your own, and which areas you need help from other people.

Improved self-confidence – Deep levels of self-awareness help you improve your self-confidence. The more you know about yourself, the more you will respect and love yourself for what you truly are.

Thus, when you are acutely self-aware, your chances for success at your workplace increase multifold.

Self-Regulation

Having control over your impulses and manifestations of your internal emotions help you in the following ways at your workplace:

Increased self-control – You will find that you are able to manage disruptive situations efficiently by keeping a check on how you respond to your own emotions triggered by the external problems. You will have better self-control over your behaviors and reactions.

Increased trustworthiness – When you handle yourself with dignity and respect through self-regulation and by maintaining standards of integrity and honesty, you will win the trust of your colleagues and team members.

Conscientiousness – You will be accountable and take responsibility for your own personal performance, and lead your team by example.

Adaptability – is the crucial element needed for business success in this rapidly changing world.

Self-regulation, therefore, makes you a strong and trustworthy professional at your workplace.

Motivation

Motivation both in the form of self-motivating as well as driving others to do their best is an essential element for the success of all kinds of businesses. High levels of motivation help you in your professional life in the following ways:

A drive to achieve better standards – You strive to constantly better yourself so that your business remains relevant and prospers in this day and age where innovation is an important thing for success.

Commitment – With motivation, you are committed to aligning yourself and those of your team with the goals of your business.

Initiative – Motivation empowers you to take the initiative and grab opportunities that come your way to achieve personal and professional success.

Optimism – You are ever-prepared to bounce back from temporary setbacks and obstacles and persist in your efforts to achieve your goals.

Emotional Intelligence and the Bottom Line of an Organization

Today, an increasing number of companies choose to include emotional intelligence as an important criterion to select candidates for jobs. In addition to technical skills, companies are looking at competencies such as assertiveness skills, stress management abilities, social and political acumen, and empathy.

Studies have proven that people with higher emotional intelligence tend to be more productive and efficient than people with lower EQ in sales, software development, and other jobs. EQ helps improve the effectiveness of a person to do well in all the fields.

When it comes to hiring, most companies choose people with a higher EQ than those with a higher IQ. In fact, even when it comes to promotions too, companies are more likely to choose people who have proven their emotion- and people-management skills rather than those who have worked for themselves.

Companies need people who manage stressful situations and who can empathize with their colleagues and teammates because it is now dawned on most corporate houses that success cannot come with smartness and intelligence alone but has to combine with emotion management and other soft skills aspects of human beings.

Chapter 12:

The Role of Emotional Intelligence for a Healthy Environment at Home

Perhaps the best test of your emotional intelligence is when you use it in romantic relationships because, in romance, emotions are usually very strong and very personal, and deep intimate connections can be forged. When you open the depths of your heart to someone, you are exposing yourself to getting hurt and rejected at a very deep level, and if the hurt is strong, then you can be scarred for life.

Falling in love has little or nothing to do with intelligence or personality. It's an experience that goes deeper than both. Romantic relationships work the best when both the partners have high levels of emotional intelligence. The more valuable a relationship is to us, the more we want to know about the partner's emotions and the reasons for the emotions.

When your partner with whom you are deeply in love feels hurt or upset about something, you feel empathy towards him or her, and we are willing to hear and accept their side of the story wholeheartedly. Another interesting phenomenon between romantic partners is that people with a fewer number of unmet needs tend to hear and empathize with the other partner's emotions and feelings better than those with many unmet needs.

For example, if one of the partners is needy, then his or her own unmet need will occupy the person's mind space, and such people are unlikely to listen to their partner's emotional needs. Taking care of their own pain is typically a survival instinct, and that unmet need will naturally take precedence over the partner's needs.

The Rationale Behind the Need for Empathy

Human beings are emotionally needy animals. We all need to know that someone loves and cares for us. When we feel pain from anger, resentment, disappointment or anything, then we want someone to empathize with our emotions, and feel the pain with us.

When we get hurt, we call attention to ourselves so that someone who cares for us will come and comfort us. Even before human beings learned and developed verbal communication, we used sounds such as cries, moans, sad tones, facial expressions of pain, etc. to let others know we need help. This was, in fact, a survival instinct for our ancestors from our cavemen days when human beings moved in tribes from place to place in search of food and shelter.

The more care the people showed to an individual, the more that person was valued in the tribe. If there was a complete lack of concern, there was a high risk that the concerned person could be left behind at some point to fend for himself or herself in which case the chances of survival were very slim. Therefore, the craving for empathy and concern from other people was, in truth, a survival instinct which is still deeply embedded in our psyche. We crave empathy, especially in pain.

However, the trick in demanding empathy in a romantic relationship is this that we must not do it when we are in pain. If we feel the need for empathy when we are in pain, and, if for some reason, our partner is unable to give it at that point in time, we turn resentful and bitter. Then, instead of being in a receiving mode, we turn into an aggressive, demanding mode and attack our partners. When human beings are attacked, the first and natural reaction is to get defensive, and how can there be empathy in such a situation?

Here is an example to illustrate this point: A girl attacks her boyfriend for not caring or not showing enough concern for her. 'You are not even bothered if I am hurt right now too, are you?' She barks at her boyfriend who was flustered for a moment. Then, he turned around, and retorted,

‘Yes, right now I’m not concerned for you. I’m only worried about how to defend myself against your verbal attacks.’

And yes, that is quite true. The more we attack, the more defensive the other person gets. You cannot really feel empathy when you are under attack. This attitude is again a survival instinct. From time immemorial, we have evolved to protect ourselves first before trying to help someone else.

Therefore, if you are looking for empathy, it is wise not to attack the person from whom you want the emotion. Avoid saying things like:

- If I’m important to you, then you would show more concern than now.
- You really don’t care about me, I think.

Even if some people decide to fall for your whines, and choose to show empathy, it would most likely be a pretense and not a genuine concern. Their insincere empathetic reaction will, most likely, be triggered by a feeling of guilt; an unhealthy emotion in any relationship. People who leverage the power of guilt to get their work done will not be able to use it for long because sooner than later, the other party will begin to feel resentful driven by the loss of power in the relationship.

Such emotional imbalances will create power struggles between the two partners, and other unhealthy emotions such as inferior, superior, defeat, victory, judgmental attitude, etc. will come into play resulting in the relationship turning very toxic.

A romantic relationship should ideally be mutually nurturing. Each partner will take turns to be the caregiver and the caretaker so that both the partners receive and give equal amounts of love, care, and concern to each other.

Therefore, considering the number of layers of emotions that come into play in a romantic relationship, it is but the strongest representation of an individual’s level of emotional intelligence.

Here are some thoughts that will help you create and maintain long-standing loving, romantic relationships:

- Ensure you are not confused between loving your partner and needing your partner. A need is reflective of dependency and insecurity. If you think you need your partner, then it means, you cannot live without him or her in your life. However, if you truly love your partner, you can let go, and, still love him or her. If you love your partner, then you don't need him or her to be happy. You can love your partner even after you have broken up.
- During the relationship, if you feel guilty or bad about something, don't hesitate to discuss your feelings with your partners. Openness and trust are critical for a strong romantic relationship. If you have done something wrong, don't hesitate to say sorry.
- If your partner does not accept your apology, then don't let that feeling fester in your mind. You forgive yourself because you found the courage to own up to your mistake, and ask for forgiveness or offer some restitution. You can only say sorry genuinely and from the depths of your heart. Accepting your apology is not under your control.
- Take responsibilities for your feelings, emotions, fears, weaknesses, and defensiveness. They are yours. Don't pass on the blame of feeling sad or depressed or angry to your partner. Discuss and express the feelings by all means but without blame, criticism, or judgment.
- Also, learn to tell your partner your needs explicitly and clearly. Don't expect him or her to read your mind.

Here are some tips to manage negative emotions in a relationship:

- First, identify the emotion.
- Express it by starting your sentence with, 'I feel...'
- Wait for your partner's response. Don't expect a response that suits you.
- Next, identify your emotions to the response.

- Use these emotions and the current situation to decide if you want to take this particular negative episode forward. In fact, if such negative emotions continue to recur in your relationship, you can also decide whether you want to take the relationship forward or not.

And finally, if many such unsuccessful relationships keep recurring in your life, then it is time to turn inwards and identify all your unmet needs that are blocking the path to a healthy and happy relationship.

Using Nonviolent Communication (NVC) to Nurture Your Relationships

Suppose there has been some bad blood between you and partner. Here is how you can use the 4-step nonviolent communication to nurture and grow your romantic relationships. Let us take this illustrative scenario: suppose you had told him about an important family party that both of you need to attend, and he said no. Words were exchanged, and before both of you realized it, it becomes a full-blown fight.

First, ask yourself what happened – This is the observation stage of the 4-step process in NVC. Observe and describe the situation without judging. What did you say? What did he say? What triggered the unpleasant scene? Answer these questions factually without your interpretations or opinions.

For example, your observation cannot be something like, ‘He rudely said no.’ You will have to simply repeat his words in your observation diary, and only quote what he said. The word, ‘rude,’ is your interpretation.

Also, in your observations, don’t bring issues of the past. Remain in the present. Keep out emotions when you are observing.

Next, describe your feelings – Now, focus on your feelings. What are your emotions? Where are you feeling them? Are there physical symptoms? Name the emotions? Don’t use language that portrays you as a victim. Avoid words such as reject, abandoned, unsupported, or misunderstood.

These are not emotions. They only represent your evaluation of other people’s action on you. You feel hurt, pain, dismayed, surprised, startled, happy, etc. When you look at your emotions and not the interpretation of the emotion, you are taking responsibility for them. There is no blame attached when you simply name emotions and not their effect on you.

Now, identify your needs – We already know that these emotions are communicating an unmet need. So, identify that underlying unmet need that is emerging through your emotion.

One of the biggest mistakes we do is to assume that our partners know all our needs. This expectation could be a residual emotion carried forward from our infancy and toddler ages when our parents or caregivers preempted every need and gave us what we want even before we knew we wanted it.

As adults, we need to outgrow this expectation. And be sensible and explicitly identify your needs, and then express it which is the fourth and final step in the NVC communication process.

Finally, express your need clearly – Once your need is identified, then express it clearly and specifically. The trick in this step is to avoid expecting a response that you want. Be ready to expect any response including receiving a no for an answer. Partners in healthy relationships feel free to voice their needs and are ready to take either a yes or a no for an answer. All this has to happen without any form of judgmental attitude.

As you talk about your needs and are open to receiving different outcomes, you will find your relationship taking better with each interaction. You will find your relationship becoming increasingly authentic and more fulfilling than before. And the most important thing, when you use the NVC method, you will know when it is time to let go of unfulfilling and toxic relationships.

Therefore, by practicing positive and awareness-enriched nonviolent communication techniques, both of you are committing yourself to give and receive love from the core of your heart.

Chapter 13:

Healthy Parenting Using Emotional Intelligence

Raising children and living childhood are both becoming increasingly difficult in this highly complex, modern-day world that is filled with material resources, and yet, devoid of resources for the heart and soul. Emotional intelligence in parenting starts with building and developing emotional intelligence in yourself.

Using emotional intelligence in parenting starts with opening your emotions to your children. Don't hide them. Let them know you feel hurt, anger, disappointment, and other negative emotions, and that these are natural aspects of human beings. However, how you express them is important.

Also, let them know that you are okay when they show anger against you. However, don't forget to tell them that when they say things like 'I hate you' in anger, then you feel hurt and pained. Taking emotional abuse from children should not be encouraged. So, letting them know that you feel hurt when they say nasty things to you, then the next time, they are angry, kids will remember this, and find alternative and more mature methods of expressing their anger.

Parenting Tips for the Emotionally Intelligent

Here are some emotional intelligence tips to help you through your parenting journey:

Treat emotions like information or data – This is, perhaps, the most challenging aspect of parenting with emotional intelligence because the relationship between parents and children is one that is filled to the brim and overflowing with feelings and emotions. You feel unconditional love, pride, anxiety, worry, anger, and other emotions with far great intensity with your child as compared to other personal relationships in your life.

Yet, if you focus and observe the emotions you are feeling as objectively as you can, and understand the underlying need, you will find it increasingly easy to look at and treat emotions like pieces of information. This objective outlook will prevent the emotions from overwhelming you which, in turn, will help you make the best choices for your child.

Treat emotions with a sense of curiosity, and you will be able to discern the information that it is trying to give you.

Parenting is a long-term marathon – Many times, parents feel like time is running out, and events in their children's lives are happening at a slower pace than other children. Parenting does not get over soon. It goes on and on, and you will need to be there for your child right through your life. So, seemingly missed chances could be an opportunity for something bigger and better. Patience and resilience are key elements that you will always need to fall back as a parent.

Things keep changing for your child. So, at times, when you feel 'there is nothing I can do to help my child do better,' or 'my child is always going to have this problem,' or 'he or she will never find the strength to overcome this,' etc., hold that thought. Step back from the moment. Remind yourself that you have a lifetime with your child, and simply revel being with your child at that moment in time, irrespective of the external circumstances.

Your child will get a lifetime of opportunities and a wide variety of choices. Hold on to your options, and the right ones for your child will come around. Adapting yourself to your child's needs will help both of you achieve the desired results of being a good parent and a good child. Running marathons is tiring and exhausting; so take breaks, and let pressure be released from time to time both for yourself and your child. See the bigger picture to help you overcome temporary setbacks.

Parenting has a long-term, and a bigger purpose that extends beyond your own children – Parenting not only affects the future of your child but also the future of the society that your child is going to live in. Parents influence an entire generation who will be the future leaders of the world. As parents, you are developing adults who will take on the baton of the world from your generation, and what they learn from you will be passed on to their children too.

When you understand **this** far-reaching purpose of parenting, it gives you a deeper sense of perspective than merely feeding, clothing, educating, and managing other needs of your children alone. When you see the big picture, you will find it easier to balance energy and other parenting resources effectively and efficiently.

Building Your Child's Emotional Intelligence

Parenting also involves building your child's emotional intelligence as well. The earlier you start this lesson, the better for your child. Here are some easy tips:

Empathize with your children and accept their perspectives – Many times, in our hurry to solve our children's problems, we don't even give them time to understand and come to terms with their emotions. Sometimes, it is important not to do anything but simply listen to your children's interpretations of their emotions which will help them understand what they are going through.

Even if you think that your child's response is a bit overboard for a particular situation, remember that just like adults, children also have stored up emotions, and this seemingly out-of-proportion reaction could be a result of earlier accumulated feelings. Most often, children hold on to their negative emotions and express them only when they come to their safe haven which is you!

Empathizing gives your children the strength to face their emotions, and they feel empowered that their perspectives matter to you. Moreover, when you give them an opportunity to voice their ideas, they will learn this lesson and know that others should also get this opportunity. Once you empathize with their emotions and hear their perspective, they will be able to see things more objectively than before. Here are some examples of how you can empathize with your children:

- 'You are so angry that it is raining, and you cannot go out and play, right?'
- 'I know it is hard for you to stop playing right now, and come for your dinner. But, you know that it is time to eat, right?'
- 'Don't you wish I could be there only for you, and forget your sisters and brothers?'
- 'I know you want to stay up late like the adults.'
- 'You are disappointed that you couldn't build your Lego tower.'

Here are some great benefits your children will experience when you show empathy and see their viewpoints:

Getting the sense of being understood is known to generate and release soothing biochemicals that strengthen the nervous system. Children will use this same power to soothe themselves when they become adults. You are, in effect, sowing the seeds of emotional intelligence in your children by empathizing with them.

- Children learn to empathize with others from your empathy towards them.
- Helping them voice their perspectives helps them understand what event triggered their flood of emotions. It is the sapling that will grow into the big, powerful tree of observation skills; the first step of the nonviolent communication process.

Don't interrupt when they are expressing their emotions – Children cannot discern between their emotions and the triggers. For them, everything is one seamless unpleasant experience. Avoid minimizing, rejecting, or interrupting the expression of your children's emotions.

For example, suppose your child says, 'I hate my sister,' and you stop his ranting with an angry, 'Don't talk like that about your sister.' You are telling your children that certain emotions are shameful and should not be expressed. This approach is the first and almost irrevocable step to curtail a child's emotional intelligence growth and development.

Your disapproval will not stop your child's emotions. It will only teach them to repress those emotions, and accumulated repressed feelings are the perfect recipe for emotional disaster. The best thing for you to do is allow your children to express their emotions fully, and let them get the feel of the entire range of human emotions during their childhood. You only teach them that these feelings are perfectly natural and show them how they can respond to these emotions in a better way.

- I can see you are furious at your sister because she broke your favorite toy. You must know that hitting her is not allowed. Use words to tell her how angry you are with her.
- You are so frustrated today because nothing seems to be going right for you. You feel like crying, right? Everyone feels like crying sometimes. Come to Mummy, and cry as much as you want.
- You are so unhappy right now. Everyone gets upset sometimes. Want to tell me about it?
- You are so angry that you want to cry and scream. Everyone feels like that sometimes, and it is okay to feel like that. Do you want to tell me or show me how angry you are?
- You are so upset that you are pushing me away. I will step back a little. But, these feelings are painful and hurt a lot, and I'm not going to leave you alone with them. I am here for you, and you are safe. Be as sad and mad as you want, and when you are finished, I will come and hug you.
- You are worried about your first field trip from school? I was also quite worried on my first trip from school. Do you want to talk about it?

Here's how this attitude benefits your child's emotional intelligence development:

Your children will find it easier to accept their negative emotions backed by your support and acceptance. Acceptance is the first step to resolve the effects of negative emotions. Your children will, sooner than later, find their own healthy ways of accepting and managing their negative emotions.

When you accept your children's expression of emotion, they will not look at these feelings as something dangerous, shameful or to be avoided. Your children will know that emotions are universal and completely natural including negative ones like anger, hate, sadness, etc. Your children will learn to accept themselves the way they are.

When you allow your children to express their emotions fully, they will understand that feelings are temporary; they come and go. They understand that if we face them, they pass easily. Some children can get so terrified of emotions overwhelming them that they try to push them away until they feel they are safe to experience. Your acceptance will give your children that safety net.

When you allow your children to feel safe and express their emotions openly, you are helping them heal. Moreover, they will learn to trust their emotional process and learn to manage their emotions on their own in a healthy way without throwing tantrums or repressing them.

Teach your children how to solve their own problems – With the above lessons, your children will learn that emotions are nothing but information and messages to read and understand, and not something to wallow in. They will learn to breathe and live through these emotions, and the feelings dissipate, teach your children how to solve their problems because now they can see things clearly.

Most times, children can solve their little problems on their own. They still haven't grown big egos. Therefore, once their emotions have passed, they will not hesitate to walk across to their friends, say sorry, shake hands, give a hug, and move on. Sometimes, they might need you to brainstorm. Don't rush in, and offer your solutions. Just be there so that they can find their own solutions. Here are some ideas:

- You are so upset that your best friend, Sally, cannot come to your birthday party because she is sick. Whenever you are ready, maybe we can talk about some fun things both of you can plan for once Sally is better, is that ok?
- You are angry that your friend John is not giving you a chance with the baseball bat. But I know you do enjoy playing with John. I wonder what you can say to John so that he knows and understands how you feel so you can play together?

Here's how this problem-solving approach will help develop emotional intelligence in your children:

- Once children have managed to handle their emotions, they must learn to take their focus off from their emotions and transfer it to problem-solving.
- They will learn that managing emotions is only half the problem solved. The other equally important part of the problem can be solved only through constructive solutions.

All children experience huge feelings on a regular basis. Most often, they feel powerless in the face of all these strange experience, and get scared and hurt. As parents, we simply need to be there for them, and let them know that feelings are normal and natural, and help them overcome the peaks. With practice, your children will learn to discern and manage their own emotions in healthy and mature ways.

Chapter 14:

Emotional Intelligence and Stress Management

Emotional intelligence is one of the most important requirements for stress management. Training your emotions can help you overcome stress because unbridled emotions tend to overwhelm and override your objective outlook.

Why do we get stressed out? The primary cause of stress in our lives is this; we all have ambitions and goals in life. But, if something happens that comes in the way of achieving our objectives, we get stressed, and emotions simply take over our lives. People with low levels of emotional intelligence look at themselves as ‘victims’ of external situations. Such people neither have nor are willing to learn the capabilities to change their reactions and responses to the situations.

Time is the most expensive and fast-depleting element for each of us. Days become months, months turn to years, and soon we get old, and we realize we have not lived at all. We are so focused on our tomorrow that we forget to experience each beautiful moment of life as it passes us by in a fleeting instant.

Emotional intelligence teaches us mindfulness. It teaches us to observe every feeling and every element of our momentary experience so that we live each moment fully and completely engaged in our life. Emotional intelligence makes us treat a life experience as a journey to be enjoyed and not as a destination to be reached. It's only when we want to reach somewhere, do we get stressed out wondering whether we will reach on time or whether we will reach at all.

Instead of treating our life as a destination to reach, if we treat our life as an unending journey, then we don't have to be stressed about anything. Here is an inspiring story of a man who refused to take life as anything else but a

journey replete with ups and downs, happy and sad emotions, and everything else in between.

A 75-year-old widower decided to join college and complete his undergraduate studies in English literature. As expected, he was the oldest student in the class, and all the other students either chose to ignore him or mocked him, sometimes subtly, and sometimes, to his face.

Joseph, for that was his name, never took this to heart, and continued to work hard, and do well in class. He never missed an opportunity to help others. He smiled heartily when jokes were made on him, and he was there when somebody needed wisdom from old people.

Soon, the age difference was forgotten, and by the time, the first semester was over, Joseph was as much part of his class as any other of his 19-20-year-old classmates. He became the center of attention, and thanks to his voracious reading habits, he was able to learn everything that was taught to him as fast as the sharp minds of his much younger classmates. In fact, when it came to learning the classics, others would approach him for help.

Soon, the four years passed, and it was graduation day. Joseph was given the honor of the valedictory speech not just because he was the oldest, and he earned the top score in his entire batch. His English was flawless, and his ready wit was bound to have everyone in splits.

He walked up to the dais, and for the first time, in the four years of college, he gave a serious speech because as he said, 'I want to leave my knowledge so that other young people can take it forward after me.' This was the gist of his speech:

It is very easy to stay young forever. You just have to learn to be happy and laugh as often as you can, find humor every day, and you have to keep dreaming. You live because you have dreams. You die when you stop dreaming. So, if you look around, and watch people walking around like as they are dead, they are actually living without a dream or a purpose.

Growing old is very different from growing up. A 20-year-old lying in bed for an entire year becomes 21 years at the end of that year. Similarly, a 75-year-old becomes 76 after one year. That is growing old. Anyone can grow old. It requires no talent or any kind of special abilities.

Growing up, on the other hand, requires you to find opportunities for success and happiness at every turn in your life. Old people rarely regret things they did in the past. They only regret things they did not do. So, go live your life each day, experiencing each moment fully.

Find reasons for joy in each and every moment of your life. Revel in your emotions without letting them overwhelm you. Make sure you experience all the emotions in your life. Don't avoid seemingly negative emotions because those are the actual teachers of success. They will teach you what mistakes you did. They will teach you to accept yourself as you are; warts and all. They will teach you the power of self-love.

In this story, Joseph died a month after that graduation day speech he gave. When he joined college to learn, he did not think of the destination. He chose just to do what he had dreamed of, and live each moment learning as much as he could, and live each moment of life with joy without worrying about tomorrow will bring.

For the stressed-out people, the first thought that is quite likely to come is this, 'What use was the college degree at 75? Why take on something so stressful at that age?' Well, that was not a question that Joseph wanted an answer to because he was not stressed about the destination that the college degree will take him. He was only interested in his journey to the college degree, the fun time he had even as he learned more and more each day, the number of new friends he made each day, and how beautifully he grew UP each day.

When Joseph died at 79, he never grew old. He only grew UP. Over 3000 students from his college came for his funeral, and there was not one set of dry eyes in the crowd. Joseph left behind a legacy that will not be forgotten for years to come. Each person he came in touch with seemed to become

more mature and more emotionally intelligent than before they met him. He was able to live life fully and unbridled, every moment of his life, and that is why stress never came anywhere near him.

Here are some ways how emotional intelligence will help you manage stress by keeping the following irrational thoughts at bay:

Irrational thought: I should have the approval of everyone I connect with.

Emotionally intelligent thought: I know wanting to be loved and approved by everyone is unrealistic. I will find happiness with whoever loves me.

Irrational thought: I have to be successful and excellent at everything I do to have high levels of self-esteem and self-worth.

Emotionally intelligent thought: It is naïve to expect perfection from myself in everything I do. It is perfectly okay to fail and make mistakes.

Irrational thought: I am so totally so stupid to have tried to do this. I don't really deserve it and that's why I didn't get it right.

Emotionally intelligent thought: What I did was stupid, and I am sorry for it. However, I am willing to forgive myself and try again.

Irrational thought: I am totally to be blamed for what happened.

Emotionally intelligent thought: I am sorry for what happened. I am at fault, but I cannot be blamed for it.

Irrational thought: It is better to avoid than face the problems in my life. Hopefully, the problems will simply go away.

Emotionally intelligent thought: While I may be able to get some respite by running away from my problems, it is best to face them, identify my role in it, and make changes that are under my control.

Irrational thought: Things are always going wrong.

Emotionally intelligent thought: I accept that sometimes things can go wrong, and that's okay, and in fact, natural.

Irrational thought: I am a total failure.

Emotionally intelligent thought: Like most other people, I am a person who does fail sometimes. But, I learn lessons, pick myself up, and try again.

Irrational thought: I have always been this way, and my past experiences have made me who I am today. I cannot change anything even if I wanted to.

Emotional intelligent thought: I believe everything in this world is up for change. I have done things in the past which have influenced my present state. However, I can learn to change myself and other elements which are under my control because both people and situations are always changing.

Irrational thought: I need something external to keep me happy. I needed someone stronger than me to find comfort and joy.

Emotionally intelligent thought: I am the maker of my own destiny. Right now, I may think I need others to be happy. But, I realize that dependence like other bad habits can be eliminated or changed.

Irrational thoughts create stress whereas thinking with the strength of emotional intelligence helps you reduce stress. Moreover, when you choose the emotionally intelligent way of thinking, you are taking control of your life. Taking control of your life means you choose what you want to do with it; do you want to turn left or right or go straight.

And when you make such conscious choices, it will be easier to manage stress better because you would have thought through the entire process, and prepared yourself for most of the potential challenges.

Conclusion

All of us are bound to have come across people in our lives who seem to have their emotions, reactions, and responses perfectly under control. People who manage toxicity at work as well as in their personal relationships. Did you wonder how they managed to do all this? Did it seem like a miracle to you?

Well, now that you have completed reading this book, I hope you realize that it is not magic that helped people lead such enviable lives. It is the power of emotional intelligence. The first step to emotional intelligence is self-awareness. That means, first learn about yourself. Look at the mirror, and love what you see because you are unique and special.

Self-awareness leads you to feel compassion for yourself first which connects you to the natural state of compassion that all human beings are born with; the core assumption of nonviolent communication. Combining the powers of nonviolent communication and high emotional intelligence, very soon, you realize you can transfer this self-compassion to others as well.

You find it easy to understand another person's perspective. Soon, you reach a stage in your journey of achieving emotional intelligence when you chide yourself gently for not seeing what others are showing you. When you make this world full of people with high levels of emotional intelligence who can relate to and connect with each other through nonviolent communication, then no conflict or disagreement can remain unresolved for long. World peace can truly take place.

Of course, the day of achieving complete world peace may be still far away. However, with emotional intelligence and nonviolent communication, you as an individual can definitely achieve stress relief, effective communication, empathy, learn to overcome challenges, and resolve conflict effectively.